



International
Labour
Organization

► **Labour market demand
in **Europe and North America:**
Prioritized destinations for
Sri Lankan migrant workers**

- ▶ **Labour market demand in Europe and North America: Prioritized destinations for Sri Lankan migrant workers**

© International Labour Organization 2024

First published 2023



Attribution 4.0 International (CC BY 4.0)

This work is licensed under the Creative Commons Attribution 4.0 International. To view a copy of this licence, please visit <https://creativecommons.org/licences/by/4.0/>. The user is allowed to reuse, share (copy and redistribute), adapt (remix, transform and build upon the original work) as detailed in the licence. The user must clearly credit the ILO as the source of the material and indicate if changes were made to the original content. Use of the emblem, name and logo of the ILO is not permitted in connection with translations, adaptations or other derivative works.

Attribution – The user must indicate if changes were made and must cite the work as follows: [*Labour market demand in Europe and North America: Prioritized destinations for Sri Lanka migrant workers*, Colombo: International Labour Office, 2024]

Translations – In case of a translation of this work, the following disclaimer must be added along with the attribution: *This is a translation of a copyrighted work of the International Labour Organization (ILO). This translation has not been prepared, reviewed or endorsed by the ILO and should not be considered an official ILO translation. The ILO disclaims all responsibility for its content and accuracy. Responsibility rests solely with the author(s) of the translation.*

Adaptations – In case of an adaptation of this work, the following disclaimer must be added along with the attribution: *This is an adaptation of a copyrighted work of the International Labour Organization (ILO). This adaptation has not been prepared, reviewed or endorsed by the ILO and should not be considered an official ILO adaptation. The ILO disclaims all responsibility for its content and accuracy. Responsibility rests solely with the author(s) of the adaptation.*

Third-party materials – This Creative Commons licence does not apply to non-ILO copyright materials included in this publication. If the material is attributed to a third party, the user of such material is solely responsible for clearing the rights with the rights holder and for any claims of infringement.

Any dispute arising under this licence that cannot be settled amicably shall be referred to arbitration in accordance with the Arbitration Rules of the United Nations Commission on International Trade Law (UNCITRAL). The parties shall be bound by any arbitration award rendered as a result of such arbitration as the final adjudication of such a dispute.

Queries on rights and licensing should be addressed to the ILO Publishing Unit (Rights and Licensing) at rights@ilo.org. Information on ILO publications and digital products can be found at: www.ilo.org/publns.

ISBN 978-922-0403-48-8 (print)

ISBN 978-922-0403-49-5 (web PDF)

The designations employed in ILO publications and databases, which are in conformity with United Nations practice, and the presentation of material therein do not imply the expression of any opinion whatsoever on the part of the ILO concerning the legal status of any country, area or territory or of its authorities, or concerning the delimitation of its frontiers or boundaries.

The opinions and views expressed in this publication are those of the author(s) and do not necessarily reflect the opinions, views or policies of the ILO.

Reference to names of firms and commercial products and processes does not imply their endorsement by the ILO, and any failure to mention a particular firm, commercial product or process is not a sign of disapproval.

Printed in Sri Lanka

► 1. Introduction

The International Labour Organization (ILO) in Sri Lanka is “promoting decent work through good governance, protection and empowerment of migrant workers: contributing towards the effective implementation of the Sri Lanka National Labour Migration Policy” under the Safe Labour Migration Project. The project’s fourth phase is structured around three objectives, the third of which is: “policymakers, public officials and other stakeholders are provided with an evidence base for their informed participation in policy, dialogue and action on labour migration”.

Foreign employment demand and supply studies provide the government with valuable insights to make informed decisions about foreign employment labour market policies, economic development strategies, and overall national planning. This helps create a balanced and sustainable migrant workforce, fostering economic growth and social stability. The Safe Labour Migration Programme of the International Labour Organization Country Office for Sri Lanka and the Maldives initiated this research study to bridge the knowledge gaps for better decisions in the foreign employment landscape, responding to the Government of Sri Lanka. This study was carried out by Nielsen IQ Lanka (Pvt) Ltd in close collaboration with the Ministry of Labour & Foreign Employment, Ministry of Foreign Affairs, Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment (SLBFE), Licensed Foreign Employment Agencies and workers’ associations.

This analysis supports the Government to pinpoint regions or countries where Sri Lankans can potentially secure higher salaries or access more promising job prospects. Moreover, it helps individuals identify regions and countries with specific skill shortages or surpluses, enabling them to align their career choices with market demand. Equally important, this analysis assists Governments in establishing focused skills development mechanisms to align with migration trends. It has further become increasingly necessary to conduct additional labour market analyses and skills mapping for foreign job placements, given constantly evolving circumstances and the role of

labour migration supporting Sri Lanka’s continued and renewed economic development.

In line with the findings of the desk research conducted under the third objective, a research study on labour market supply and demand for Sri Lankan migrant workers was commissioned. This document presents those findings.

Study objectives

The researchers were asked to look in depth at the following issues and to map out the supply and demand for skills and labour and highlight the gaps and opportunities that would allow them to make recommendations for improving the foreign employment options for women and men seeking to migrate out of Sri Lanka.

1. The current mid-term and long-term labour demand in countries of the Middle East, Europe and North America and the Asia-Pacific for women and men migrant workers.
2. The similarities and overlap in labour demand across the different migration corridors.
3. The current labour supply in Sri Lanka, including profiles of aspiring women and men migrant workers, their skills and qualifications and the available skills training and qualifications facilities in Sri Lanka.

These objectives were further broken down into the following research questions.

Labor market demand

- What are the immediate, medium-term and long-term labour market demands in the Middle East, Europe and South and South-East Asia for women and men migrant workers from Sri Lanka?
- What are the labour and employment sectors that are most in demand and for most countries and regions in the immediate, medium and long term, disaggregated according to gender, skill category and earning potential?

- What are the employment and recruitment pathways (processes) for the in-demand labour sectors?
- What are the labour and employment sectors in countries and regions of destination that best align with the national economic and development strategies in Sri Lanka (with a view to the sustainable reintegration of migrant workers)?
- Do the existing qualifications and certification opportunities available in Sri Lanka sufficiently cater to the requirements of the in-demand foreign employment sectors? What are the gaps and how could they be addressed?
- Are the existing qualifications and certification opportunities in Sri Lanka adequately recognized in the targeted countries and regions of destination by potential employers and do they result in sufficient wage increases?

Labour market supply

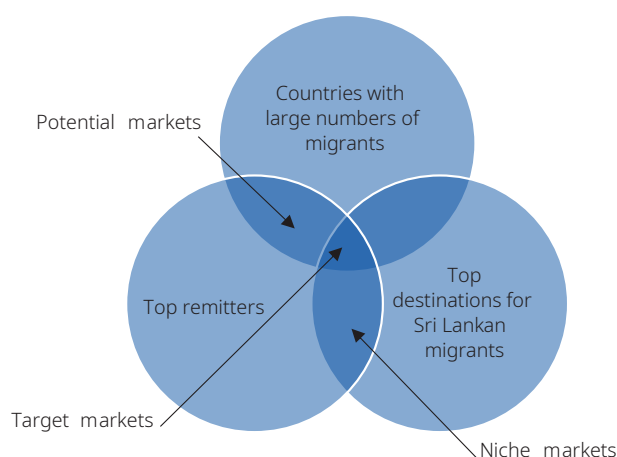
- What is the profile of aspiring migrant workers from Sri Lanka, disaggregated by age, gender and skill category?
- What are the existing expertise and skills within this population of aspiring women and men migrant workers?
- What are the qualification and certification opportunities available to aspiring women and men migrant workers, including the time and cost implications of completing additional certifications?
- What are the areas that the Government of Sri Lanka should focus on for investment, particularly regarding skills training and certifications that would result in improved employment opportunities for migrant workers?

Skills mapping

- Are the existing populations of aspiring women and men migrant workers sufficiently qualified or certified to meet the requirements of the in-demand foreign employment labour sectors? If not, how could they be improved?

The overarching objective of the research study was to identify and map the demand for migrant workers in destination countries and the supply from Sri Lanka. After further discussions with the Ministry of Labour and Foreign Employment, it was decided that the research would give more emphasis to identifying demand and then mapping the current supply against it, as opposed to more emphasis on supply. This was with the expectation that the Ministry would use the findings of this research to develop and implement the short-term and long-term policies and actions to equip Sri Lankan migrant workers to meet the demand of global migrant worker market and take the necessary steps to facilitate labour migration that would be conducive to the country's further development. It was also emphasized that exploration of migration corridors that are not in the current radar for Sri Lanka is also needed.

Figure 1. Criteria for selecting countries with high potential for Sri Lankan migrants



► Contents

► Desk research findings

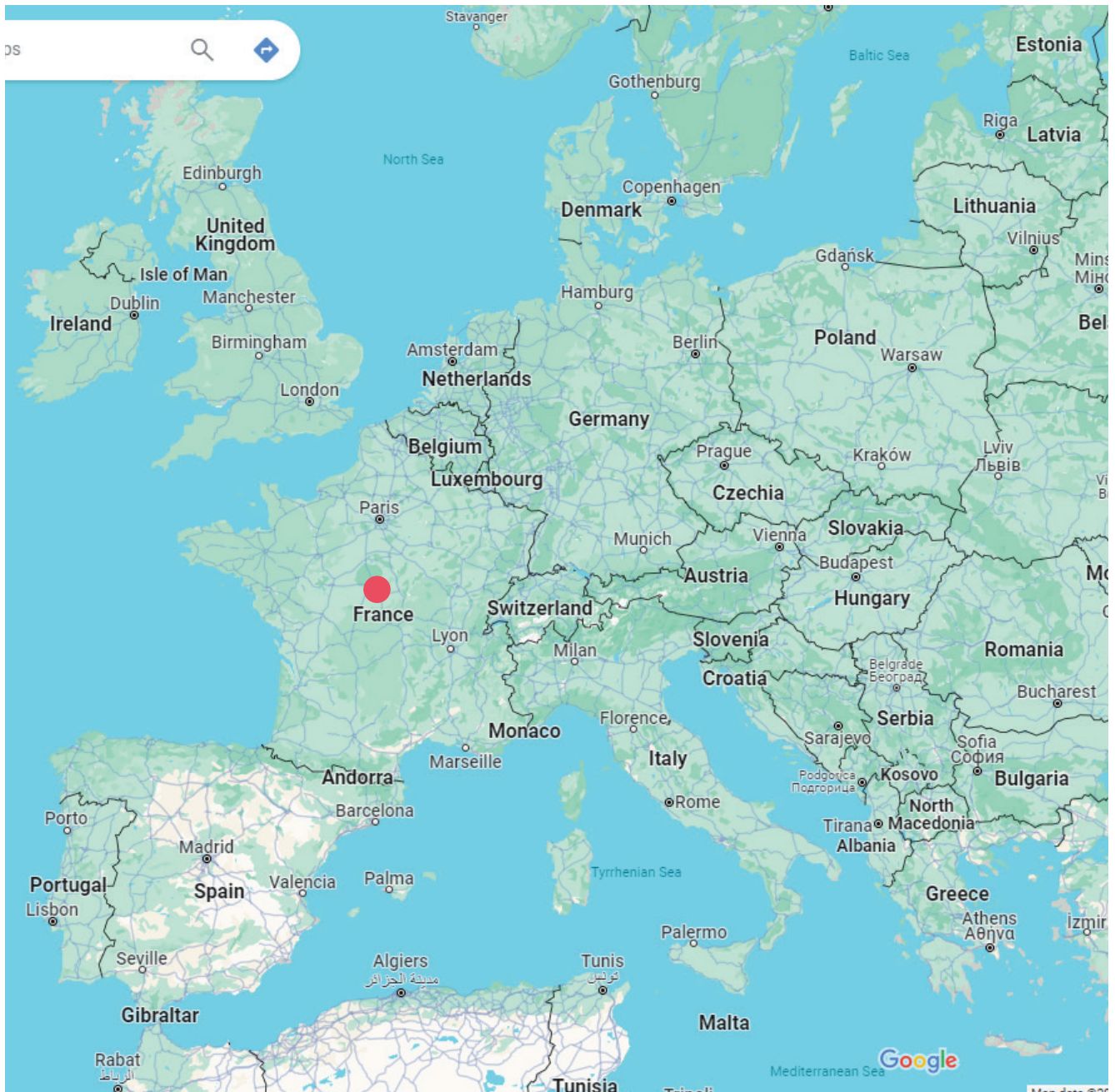
► France	1
► Germany	11
► Italy	21
► United Kingdom	31
► Cyprus	45
► Ireland	49
► Romania	55
► Canada	59
► United States of America	73

► Tables

Table 1.1	Immigrants in France, by country of birth, 2020	4
Table 1.2	Most-in-demand jobs in France and highly paid jobs, 2023	4
Table 1.3	Occupations with labour shortages in France, 2023	5
Table 2.1	International migrants in Germany, by age category, as of mid-2020	13
Table 2.2	Sectors considered particularly hard hit with skilled labour shortages in Germany, 2021	15
Table 3.1	Top-five migrant-sending countries to Italy, 2020	23
Table 3.2	Most difficult-to-fill categories per each education attainment level in Italy, 2022	25
Table 3.3	Sectors in Italy that could generate high demand for workers with green economy skills	25
Table 4.1	Top-five migrant-sending countries to the United Kingdom, 2020	34
Table 4.2	The 13 trends with great influence on jobs and skills in the United Kingdom, to 2030	36
Table 4.3	Top-ten shortage occupations in the United Kingdom, as of June 2023	36
Table 5.1	Top-five migrant-sending countries to Canada, 2020	62
Table 5.2	Growth sectors and sectors with decline in labour in Canada, 2019–22 (%)	64
Table 5.3	Top-five industries with increased wages in Canada, 2019 Q1–2022 Q1 (%)	64
Table 6.1	Top-five migrant-sending countries to the United States, 2020	76
Table 6.2	Ten-fastest growing occupations and median annual wages in the United States, 2021–31 (US\$)	77

► Figures

Figure 1.1	International migrants in France, by age, 2020	3
Figure 2.1	International migrants in Germany, by age and gender, 2020	13
Figure 2.2	Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment-registered migrants in Germany, by skill level, 2021	16
Figure 3.1	International migrants in Italy, by gender, 2020	23
Figure 3.2	International migrants in Italy, by age category, 2020	23
Figure 3.3	Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment-registered migrants in Italy, 2021	26
Figure 3.4	Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment-registered migrants in Italy, by gender, 2021	26
Figure 3.5	Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment-registered migrants in Italy, by skill category, 2021	26
Figure 4.1	International migrants in the United Kingdom, by gender, 2020	33
Figure 4.2	International migrants in the United Kingdom, by age, 2020	33
Figure 4.3	Percentage of foreign-born population in the United Kingdom, by occupation, 2011	34
Figure 4.4	Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment-registered migrants in the United Kingdom, 2018, 2019 and 2021	37
Figure 4.5	Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment-registered migrants in the United Kingdom, by gender, 2021	38
Figure 4.6	Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment-registered migrants in the United Kingdom, by skill level, 2021	38
Figure 5.1	International migrants in Canada, by gender, 2020	61
Figure 5.2	International migrants in Canada, by age category, 2020	61
Figure 5.3	Percentage of foreign-born population in Canada, by occupation, 2016	62
Figure 5.4	Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment-registered migrants in Canada, 2021	65
Figure 5.5	Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment-registered migrants in Canada, by gender, 2021	65
Figure 5.6	Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment-registered migrants to Canada, by skill category, 2021	66
Figure 6.1	International migrants in the United States, by gender, 2020	75
Figure 6.2	International migrants in the United States, by age category, 2020	75



France

► Background

1. France

a. Migrant population in France

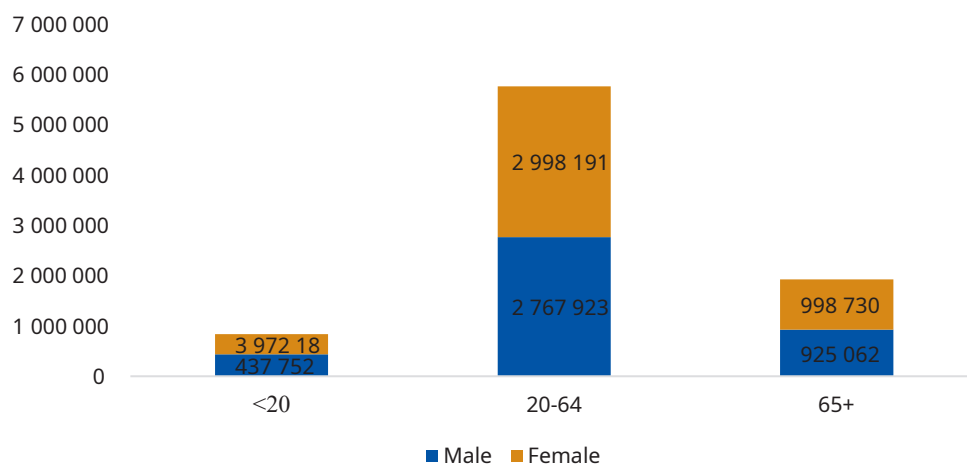
In the scoring system used for this study, France placed within the top-ten countries in terms of remittances to Sri Lanka but it did not fare highly in the other two criteria, thus landing twelfth among the fifteen countries in terms of potential for skilled and professional Sri Lankan migrants.

According to the *World Migration Report 2022*, France is the seventh-largest destination country for international migrants. According to the French National Institute of Statistics and Economic Studies,

the 2021 Census counted nearly 7 million immigrants (foreign-born people) in France, representing 10.3 per cent of the total population.¹

According to the UN DESA statistics on the international migrant population), 8,524,876 migrants lived in France in 2020. Of them, 4,130,737 were men and 4,394,139 were women, with more than half of them (5,766,114) of in working age, 20–64, (figure 49).

Figure 1.1. International migrants in France, by age, 2020



Source: UN DESA, Population Division, “International migration stock 2020”.

The net migration rate for France in 2022 was 0.883 per 1,000 population, a 9.96 per cent increase from 2021.²

In 2018, France received 277,000 new migrants on a long-term or permanent basis. Of them, 30 per cent had benefited from free mobility within the Europe, 14.5 per cent were declared labour migrants, 36.7 per cent were family members, and 11 per cent were

humanitarian migrants. The labour participation rate for foreign-born individuals was 67.8 per cent and employment rate for them was 58.9 per cent in 2019.

The top-three migrant-sending countries to France in 2020 (latest available data) were Algeria (853,466), Morocco (802,806) and Portugal (601,762).

¹ French National Institute of Statistics and Economic Studies, “Immigration to France”, n.d.

² MacroTrends, “France Net Migration Rate 1950–2023”, n.d.

Table 1.1. Immigrants in France, by country of birth, 2020

Country of birth	Migrant population
Algeria	853 466
Morocco	802 806
Portugal	601 762
Other countries of Europe	482 942
Tunisia	302 379

Source: French National Institute of Statistics and Economic Studies, “Immigrants By Country of Birth – Immigrants and Immigrant Descendants”.

Of the 1,673,200 foreign nationals in the workforce in 2018, the largest sector – comprising almost 300,000 people – was services, such as security and cleaning of professional premises, hairdressing, housekeeping and home help. This was followed

by the construction industry, where 247,300 foreign workers were employed. Table 32 lists most in-demand jobs in France, in order, with the salary range, and a comparison with the highest-paid jobs.

Table 1.2. Most-in-demand jobs in France and highly paid jobs, 2023

Most in-demand jobs	Salary range (per year)	Highly paid jobs	Average annual salary
1. Insurance agent	€40 000–€60 000	Surgeons and doctor	€184 000
2. Software engineer	€40 000–€60 000	Judge	€155 000
3. Data analyst	€35 000–€75 000	Lawyer	€125 000
4. Childcare specialist	€10 000–€25 000	Bank manager	€118 000
5. School teacher	€25 000–€45 000	Chief executive officer	€111 000
6. Nurse	€30 000–€55 000	Chief financial officer	€103 000
7. Front-end web developer	€35 000–€50 000	Orthodontist	€99 500
8. IT technician	€37 000–€50 000	College professor	€88 500
9. Real estate agent	€25 000–€53 000	Pilot	€73 700
10. Project manager	€50 000–€80 000	Marketing director	€66 400

Source: Grabjobs.co, “Top 15 Most In-demand Jobs in France in 2023”; Salary Explorer, “Best Paying Jobs in France”, 2023.

b. Migration policy in France

The 2018 law prolonged the validity of the “talent passport” residence permit, initially established by a 2016 law, to four years. Family members (spouse and children) can obtain this permit without undergoing a family reunification process. In December 2019,

a circular was dispatched to prefectures proposing organizational enhancement for application processing. The Government revealed plans to institute a sector specific professional immigration policy, aligning with the updated regional Shortage Occupational Lists (not updated since 2008).³

3 OECD, *International Migration Outlook 2020*, 2020.

France intends to introduce a residence permit for undocumented workers already within the country, specifically tailored for occupations facing labour shortages. This initiative will be accompanied by measures aimed at streamlining deportation procedures.

c. Labour demand and trends in France

The most sought-after professions in France for foreigners are in the fields of agriculture and tourism. For example, harvesters for grapes and other fruit crops are needed and the tourism sector requires waiters, maids, bartenders, instructors, guides and assistant cooks.⁴ Mostly it is work in bars, cafes, restaurants, hotels, camping sites and ski resorts. Although France is an extremely popular tourist destination, the travel and tourism sector is reportedly experiencing a severe labour shortage –

according to the World Travel and Tourism Council, around 70,000 jobs remain unfilled across the country.⁵

Housekeepers, nannies and caregivers, deemed low-skilled, are in demand in France. There are opportunities in construction sites for men as electricians, carpenters, plumbers, painters and handymen.

As per information from local employment agencies, the sought-after occupations in France in 2023 include machine operators, carpenters, butchers and programmers. Similar to global trends, there is a demand for skilled engineers and construction workers. Overall, the French labour market is currently grappling with a significant shortage of qualified personnel (table 33).

Table 1.3. Occupations with labour shortages in France, 2023

1 Engineer (different directions)

2 Marketing manager

3 Butcher

4 Machine operator

5 Carpenter

6 Programmer (different directions)

7 Worker in agriculture

8 Builder (different directions)

9 Social worker

10 Specialist in tourism

Source: : Data from the French employment agency and international recruitment agencies, see Wage Centre, “Shortage Occupations in France in 2023”.

4 Wage Centre, “Shortage Occupations in France in 2023”.

5 Shengen Visa News, “70,000 Jobs Remain Unfilled in France’s Travel & Tourism Sector, WTTC Says”, 3 August 2022.

The designated minimum wage in France stands at €1,709.28 per month, with an hourly rate of €11.27. As of 2023, the average monthly salary in the country hovers around €3,085 or €2,400 net, while income tax varies from 14 per cent to 45 per cent. Notably, the highest earning occupations include practicing doctors and management companies representing large business.⁶

d. Migration to France from Sri Lanka

According to the Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment, only two Sri Lankans registered as

migrant workers in France in 2021, which was up from one in 2018 and 2020 (with two in 2019). According to the Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment website, there are no vacancies available for Sri Lankans in France.⁷

According to KNOMAD's bilateral remittance matrix, US\$155 million in remittances to Sri Lanka originated in France in 2021.⁸

6 See Wage Centre, "Shortage Occupations in France in 2023".

7 SLBFE, "Foreign job Vacancies", n.d.

8 KNOMAD, "Bilateral Remittance Matrix 2021", n.d.

French labour market demand

Recruitment pathways	Challenges and barriers	Skill gaps to be bridged	Visa process recommendations
France is a highly restricted and controlled job market for migrant workers. Priority is given to workers from the French colony countries. Highly skilled local workers can apply for job opportunities listed in websites. If employers don't find required qualifications from such candidates, they make a request for the Government to find a suitable person from outside and offer free visa for them. Job opportunities are found mostly through personal contacts.	- Lack of fluency in French and English - French language required for health sector professionals, such as dentists and nurses	- Language proficiency in French (required for professional categories) - English language proficiency (required)	A "high tech visa" is available for professional categories. The work visa provided directly through the employer. Permanent residency can be applied only through refugee visa at the moment. A social security number is needed for refugee visa. Students can apply to bachelor's or master's degree programmes. Students are allowed to work part-time while studying. After completing their degree, students can apply for jobs and settle down in France with a work visa. *Visit visa to France does not allow for work permits.

Immediate and mid-term opportunities, 1-2 years		
Job category	Required qualifications (acceptance for local qualifications)	Work experience
Professional and skilled IT professional in system development and hardware functions Dentist, nurse, health care assistant *There are few semi-skilled opportunities for plumbers, electricians, etc. *There are fewer Sri Lankan skilled workers in France due to the recruitment restrictions for migrant workers.	<i>(French language skills are preferred for all the categories of jobs.)</i> Sri Lankan academic qualifications and professional qualifications are recognized for health and IT sector professionals. The Higher National Diploma level for nursing is recognized. For semi-skilled applicants, the German Tech, technical colleges and related vocational training qualifications (NVQ levels 4-7) are recognized. IELTS and French language proficiency are essential.	A minimum work experience of 3-5 years is required for all professional and skilled categories.

Long-term opportunities, 3-5 years
<i>The focus will continue to provide opportunities to the colonial countries for semi-skilled and low-skilled workers.</i> High tech visa, with a 2-year contract and extendable visa Adult caregiver, nursing officer in health sector

French labour market demand

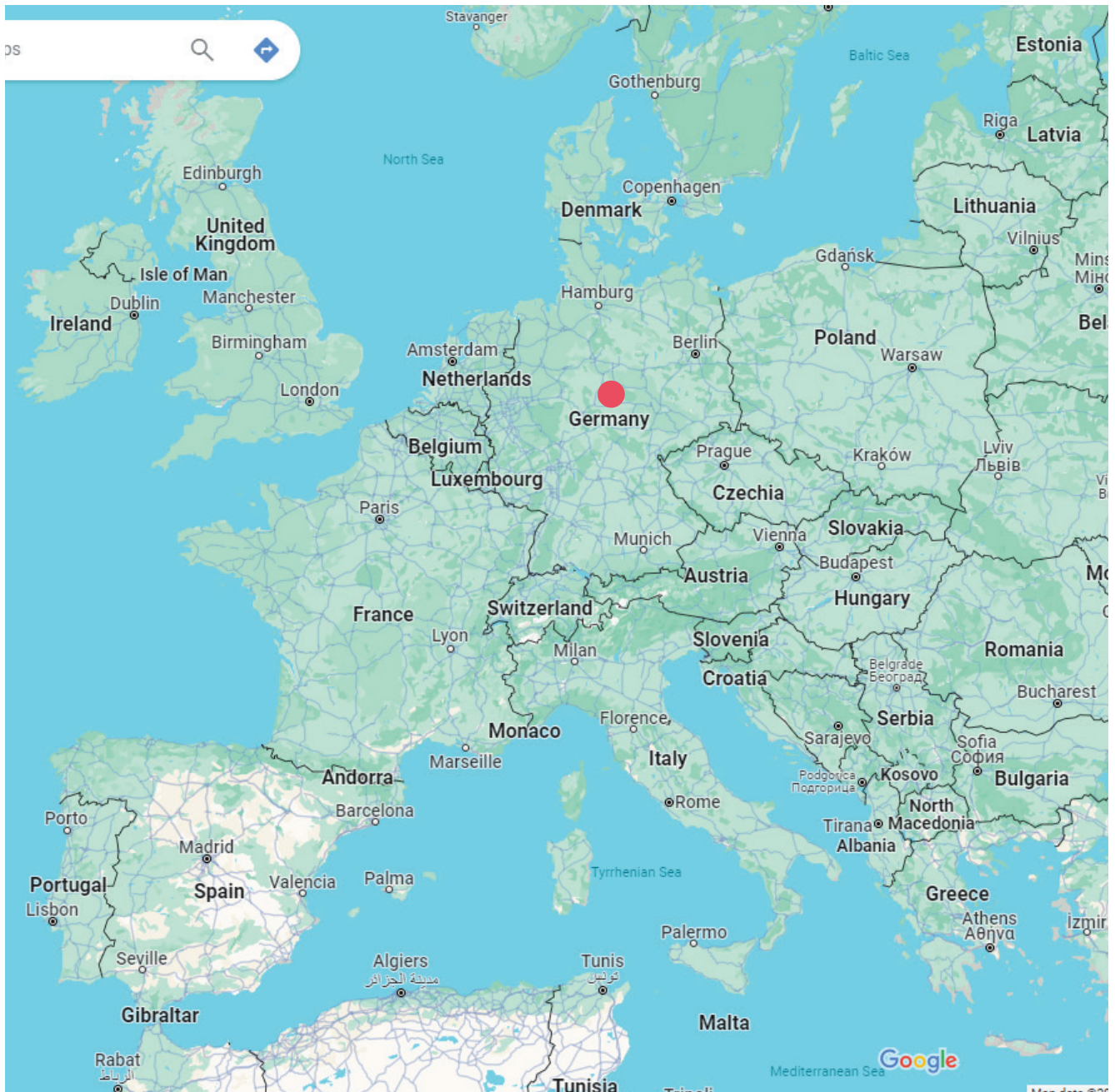
Sector	Skill category	Occupation category	Education and Skill requirements	Time period	Salary benefits
Health, caregiving	Skilled, professional	Doctor	A medical degree from a nationally recognized university is required, with 5 years of clinical experience. Applicants must have finished medical school and specialty training and must have a certificate demonstrating conformity with European Union directives. Applicants also must be proficient in French to practise as a medical practitioner in France. And they must have good French language level, such as B2.	2022–30	Minimum salary of €1,700–€4,000 per month for skilled and professional jobs
Health and care	Skilled, professional	Nurse Nursing assistant	A bachelor's degree in nursing is enough for applicants who studied in the European Union. Anyone with a nursing degree from a non-European Union country needs to have their degree evaluated and will most likely need to continue their study in France. Proof of French language skills is required.	2022–30	
Health and care	Skilled, professional	Midwife	At least two years of professional experience as a midwife are required, along with recent clinical experience (at least six months within the past 24 months). If working as an independent midwife, previous experience must include extensive numbers of deliveries as well as prenatal and postnatal care and relevant experience in hospital settings.		
Health and care	Skilled, professional	Hospital administrator	Applicants must have a bachelor's degree in health administration or a related field, such as nursing, health management, public health or public policy. While a bachelor's degree is an entry-level requirement for most hospital administration jobs, many employers might prefer candidates with a relevant master's degree.		
Health and care	Low-skilled	Caregiver Maintenance worker Domestic worker	No high school diploma is required. But applicants must have completed a four-year programme and pass the certification exam for home carers for older persons or people with disabilities. Experience in similar capacity is preferable.		

French labour market demand

Sector	Skill category	Occupation category	Education and Skill requirements	Time period	Salary benefits
Information technology	Skilled, professional	Security analyst IT technician Software developer Software engineer	An academic degree in computer science, IT or equivalent is required. Applicants must have 5 or more years of experience in technology and be fluent in English. French is a plus.		
Transportation	Low-skilled	Driver of all types	At least 5 years of experience working as a professional driver is required.		
Education	Skilled, professional	School teacher Childcare specialist	Bachelor's degree in the subject an applicant wants to teach is required, as well as a certificate or degree in education, preferably a master's degree.		

Recommendations for France

- Sri Lanka should identify long-term opportunities for the future and work towards establishing ties with the Government for migrant workers to access jobs in France.
- Sri Lanka should establish government-to-government MOUs to channel opportunities for the professionals and skilled jobseekers.
- French language courses should be offered through public-private partnerships for students at vocational training colleges, nursing schools and language academies.



Germany

► Background

2. Germany

a. Migrant population in Germany

In the scoring system used for this study, Germany placed eleventh among countries of top remitters to Sri Lanka and was eighth overall. According to the International Organization for Migration's World Migration Report 2022, Germany is the second-largest destination country for international migrants.

According to UN DESA statistics for international migrants as of mid-2020, there were 15,762,457 migrants in Germany. Of them, 7,891,635 were men and 7,870,822 were women, and most were aged 20–64 (table 21).

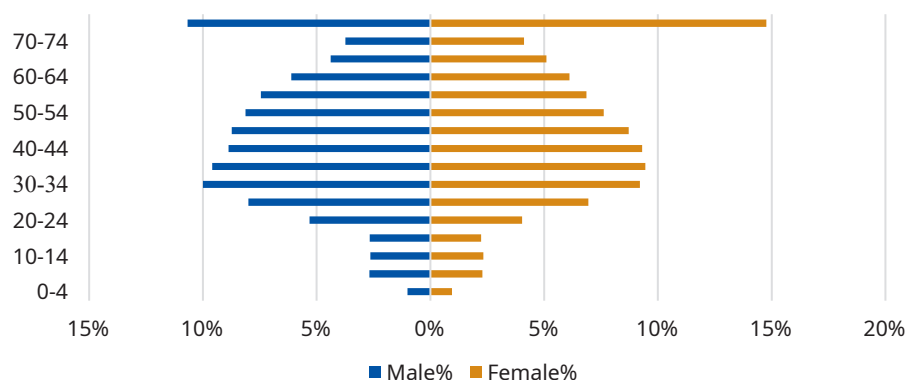
Table 2.1. International migrants in Germany, by age category, as of mid-2020

Age category	Migrant population
Younger than 20	1 323 893
20–64	11 067 885
65 and older	3 370 679

Source: UN DESA, Population Division, "International Migration Stock 2020".

The net migration rate for Germany in 2020 was 4.632 per 1,000 population, which was a 17.3 per cent decline from the 2019 rate.

Figure 2.1. International migrants in Germany, by age and gender, 2020



Source: UN DESA, Population Division, "International Migration Stock 2020".

According to OECD statistics, Germany received 631,000 new migrants in 2018 who came on a long-term or permanent basis (including changes of status and free mobility). This represented a reduction of 26.7 per cent from the number in 2017. It comprised 60.7 per cent of migrants benefiting from free mobility, 10.3 per cent who were labour migrants, 15.4 per cent family members (including accompanying family) and 12.4 per cent humanitarian migrants.⁹ Around 48,000 entry permits were issued to tertiary-level international students and 29,000 to temporary and seasonal labour migrants (excluding intra-European Union migration). The majority of the immigrants in 2020 were from Europe (69.1 per cent), followed by Romania (185,924 immigrants), Poland (103,496 immigrants) and Bulgaria (72,734 migrants).¹⁰

b. Migration policy in Germany

In June 2019, the Government approved a package of migration-related laws. The Skilled Immigration Act, which came into force in 2020, opens the labour market to skilled non-European Union migrants who have had vocational training. The Skilled Immigration Act enables third-country nationals with qualified vocational training to enter Germany to obtain employment or to have their professional qualifications recognized. Labour migrants with an employment contract or job offer no longer need to undergo a labour market test to work in occupations with labour shortage. Despite the law coming into effect in 2021 only about 25,000 skilled workers in total came to Germany under the new rules.

In 2022, the Cabinet adopted a new skilled labour strategy that provides for an immigration policy that strengthens the Skilled Immigration Act with administrative reforms in recruitment. As part of this, the Government published a white paper on amending the law on skilled labour immigration, with the objective of making the recruitment of such workers from developing countries for the German labour market simpler and quicker.

In 2023, Germany is to become even more attractive for skilled workers from around the world: A new law is planned to make it easier and faster for people from countries outside the European Union to enter the labour market. The Federal Ministry of Labour and Social Affairs is expected to introduce a new immigration possibility for skilled foreign workers with the creation of an “opportunity card” that will be issued according to a points-based system. It includes four criteria: applicants should be 35 or younger, have a degree, have at least three years of work experience and have language skills or a previous stay in Germany.

c. Labour demand and trends in Germany

One of the main challenges that Germany faces is its ageing population and low birth rate. Thus, the Government estimates the country needs at least 400,000 skilled migrants annually to keep up with the labour demand. Germany will continue experiencing massive labour shortages (table 22) unless it begins recruiting skilled immigrants to replace workers retiring from the country’s ageing workforce.

⁹ OECD, *International Migration Outlook 2020*, 2020.

¹⁰ Federal Office for Migration and Refugees. 2023. Migration Report 2020: Key Results. Bundesamt für Migration und Flüchtlinge.

Table 2.2. Sectors considered particularly hard hit with skilled labour shortages in Germany, 2021

Social sector and social education: This sector had an average of 20,500 vacant positions for educators in 2021 and 2022.

Health and care: Care professions require skills training with qualification or a degree. In 2021–22, 18,300 posts were available in geriatric care and 16,800 in health care and nursing.

Construction and skilled crafts: Sectors such as electrical construction; plumbing, heating and air-conditioning technology; and construction planning and supervision have had a severe labour shortage that grew more so in 2021. There were 87,500 vacancies in the manual trades that were not filled in 2021. Here, the lack is especially in skilled workers who have obtained their professional qualification.

Information technology: In 2021, the skilled labour gap increased to about 28,700 workers, a record high.

Science, technology, engineering and mathematics: A total of 320,600 STEM jobs had a reported labour shortage in 2022. The largest shortage (136,300 jobs) was skilled workers who had completed their professional training.

Source: German Institute for International and Security Affairs, *Germany is Looking for Foreign Labour*, 2023.

Germany is preparing to pass a new national law that will make it easier for foreigners to obtain German citizenship as part of a broader shake-up of its immigration policy aimed at strengthening the country's shrinking workforce. Additionally, there is a push to hire well-trained employees in almost all sectors. There is high demand for doctors and nursing staff, IT specialists, climate technicians, engineers and, in the wake of the expansion of renewable energies, specialists in the fields of heating and engineering technology.

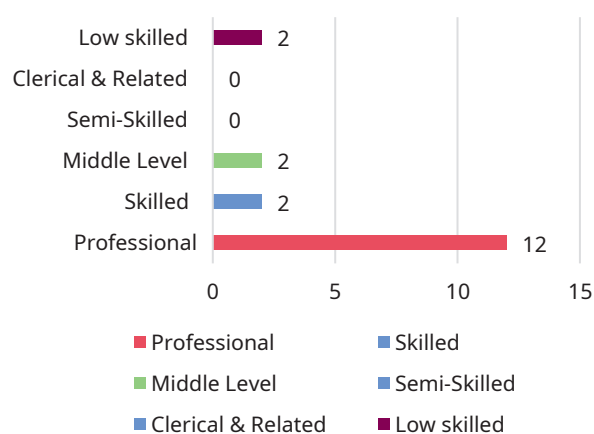
Businesses in the hotel and restaurant sectors as well as the logistics sector have been seeking personnel. Apart from skilled labour, the demand

for low-skilled qualified workers also has been growing, for instance, in the help and household-related services.

d. Migration to Germany from Sri Lanka

According to the Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment, 18 Sri Lankans registered as migrant workers in Germany in 2021 (figure 33).

Figure 2.2. Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment-registered migrants in Germany, by skill level, 2021



Source: Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment statistics, 2021.

According to KNOMAD's the bilateral remittance matrix, Sri Lankan migrants in Germany remitted US\$150 million in 2021.¹¹ Currently, Germany is seeking 400 nurses from Sri Lanka.¹²

¹¹ KNOMAD, "Bilateral Remittance Matrix 2021", n.d.

¹² SLBFE, "Foreign Job Vacancies", n.d.

German labour market demand

Recruitment pathways	Challenges and barriers	Skill gaps to be bridged	Visa process
There are no established channels for job recruitment in Germany. It is usually through a subsidiary or business partner company in Sri Lanka or through LinkedIn social media network.	- Lack of German or English fluency to converse - German Tech students not fluent in German - IT sector has fewer or no barriers for German language fluency - Migrant workers from Poland, Croatia, Philippines and India provide cheap labour, with advantage of language proficiency in English - Inability to find opportunities to match with skills and qualifications (some qualified Sri Lankan lawyers work at hotels or restaurants)	- Language proficiency in German - English language proficiency	Work visa is acquired through the employer for a contract period of 2–3 years. Postgraduate or master's programme students can obtain a visa through a university sponsorship.

Immediate and mid-term opportunities, 1–2 years		
Job category	Required qualifications (acceptance for local qualifications)	Work experience
Professional or skilled Health sector: nurse, caregiver (knowledge in German is essential) IT sector: Software and hardware engineer (more hardware and software engineering and cyber security-related opportunities, including in Estonia, a neighbouring country to Germany that also has more opportunities for IT sector migrants)	German language skills are essential for all job categories. Sri Lankan academic qualifications and professional qualifications are recognized. This includes the degree and diploma in nursing and Sri Lankan nursing registration as well as a certificate course in caregiving for adults. German Tech and technical colleges and related vocational training qualifications are recognized (NVQ levels 4–7). IELTS and German language proficiency are essential.	Minimum work experience of 3–5 years for all professional and skilled categories is required. Work experience commendation certificates are much recognized in the similar capacity or field.
Skilled and semi-skilled Construction and automobile industries (as an industrial hub, Germany has more opportunities for the semi-skilled migrants in technical jobs, such as electrician, plumber and welder in construction field as well as motor mechanics and technicians in the automobile industry)		

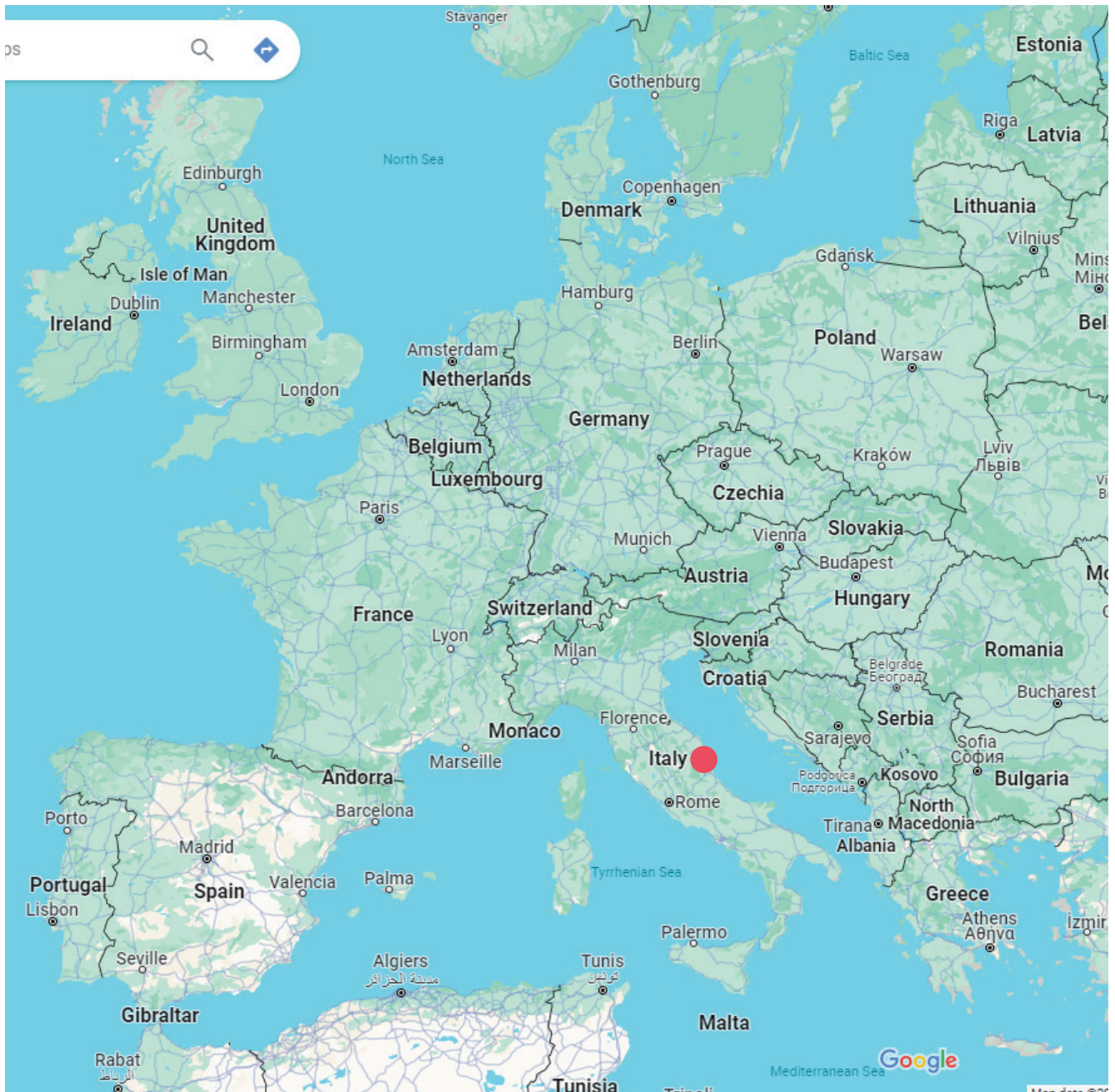
Long-term opportunities, 3–5 years
Professional and skilled Health sector: adult caregiver, mental health caregiver Cyber security (highly paid jobs with no language barrier) Green energy and technology engineer, technician in the industrial sector

German labour market demand

Sector	Skill category	Occupation category	Education and Skill requirements	Time period	Salary benefits
Health and care	Skilled, professional	Doctor	Applicants must have graduated from medical studies from a country of the European Union, the European Economic Area or Switzerland, or they must have graduated from medical studies from another country or successfully passed examination of professional knowledge (Kenntnisprüfung German language exam) in Germany. They must have medical German at C1 level and pass the Medical German Language Test.	In the Shortage Occupation List in 2023, and demand for these jobs are expected in the next few years too.	€50,000 per annum upwards for skilled professionals Students are provided work visa upon completion of the study programme. Students are allowed to work part-time while studying.
Health and care	Skilled, professional	Nursing staff	Applicants must have a university degree and a registered nurse license from Sri Lanka. They also must have good command of the German language, at level B1 or B2 from the GOETHE/TELC/OSD.		
Information technology	Skilled, professional	IT specialist	Applicants must have completed vocational training in the IT field or comparable experience. Fluent in English and German is a plus.	In the Shortage Occupation List in 2023, and demand for these jobs are expected in the next few years too.	
Information technology	Skilled, professional	Software developer Software engineer	Applicants must have a bachelor's degree in computer science, engineering or a related field. They are expected to have a basic understanding of cloud computing concepts and a strong willingness to learn. Experience with programming languages, such as Python, Java or Node.js, is expected.		
Climate technician	Skilled, professional	GIS geodata specialist	Applicants must have bachelor's degree in land management, forestry, geoinformatics, geomatics, remote sensing or similar field. Basic GIS knowledge (QGIS or ArcGIS) is preferred.		
Construction	Skilled, professional	Civil engineering Mechanical engineer	Applicants must have at least 5 years of experience in similar capacity and a diploma or master's degree in civil engineering or mechanical engineering. Several years of experience within infrastructure projects. They must be fluent in English and German, while knowledge of French and/or another language is an asset.		
Construction	Low-skilled labour	Construction worker Welder Carpenter	Applicants must have at the least 1 or 2 years of experience in civil construction is preferable. Fluent communication skills in German is preferred.		

Recommendations for Germany

- An MOU with the relevant German government authorities should be established that identifies specific job categories for Sri Lankan migrants.
- German Tech should establish a compulsory German language course in the study programme to prepare aspiring migrant workers to work in Germany.
- Public-private partnerships should be initiated to provide short duration German language courses to be learned before leaving the country.
- A quality matching framework should be adopted by the Sri Lankan Government through the universities and technical colleges.
- With more opportunities in the industrial sector, German Tech could be established as a pathway to cater to the job market in Germany.



Italy

► Background

03. Italy

a. Migrant population in Italy

Italy placed fourteenth among the total 15 countries, despite not traditionally in the pool of popular destinations. But it clearly now offers huge potential for Sri Lankan migrant workers. The country ranks highly in terms of migrant populations and remittances to Sri Lanka, even though only a few Sri Lankan migrants heading to Italy have registered

with the Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment over the past few years.

According to UN DESA statistics, a total of 6,386,998 migrants lived in Italy in 2020, constituting 10 per cent portion of the population and with more women than men. Most of the migrant population was aged 20–64 (figures 51 and 52).

Figure 3.1. International migrants in Italy, by gender, 2020

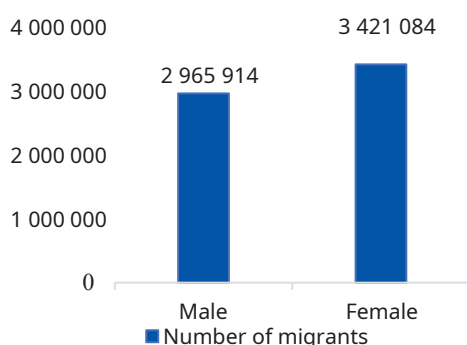
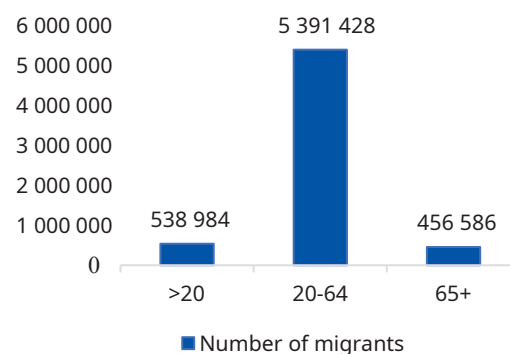


Figure 3.2. International migrants in Italy, by age category, 2020



Source: UN DESA, Population Division, “International Migration Stock 2020”.

As OECD statistics indicate, the labour market participation rate of foreign-born persons in 2021 in Italy was 68.2 per cent, which was quite lower than the average (75.7 per cent) for OECD countries. The foreign-born employment rate (at 59.3 per cent)

also was lower than the average OECD rate (at 69.2 per cent).¹³ And as reported in the World Migration Report 2022, the top-five migrant-sending countries to Italy in 2020 were Romania, Albania, Morocco, Ukraine and China (table 35).

Table 3.1. Top-five migrant-sending countries to Italy, 2020

Country	Migrant population
Romania	1 048 862
Albania	486 187
Morocco	451 960
Ukraine	248 460
China	233 338

Source: IOM, *World Migration Report 2022*, 2022.

13 OECD, *International Migration Outlook 2022*, 2022.

b. Migration policy in Italy¹⁴

Italy became a popular migration destination country during 1970–80. Since then, the foreign population has regularly increased. Various government administrations made attempts to regularize the migration process during 1986–2002. Due to polarized political debate, lack of proper developed administrative structures and weak implementation capacities, the migrant recruitment remained an inefficient process, and irregular migrants working in the informal economy increased. More attempts have been made (in 2009, 2012 and 2020) to reform the migration policy.

According to the OECD International Migration Outlook 2021 and 2022, the recent migrant policy changes are due to the change of Government and the COVID-19 pandemic. The reforms have included regularization of irregular migrants and changes to the annual quota for seasonal and non-seasonal workers. A national plan to address exploitation and illegal recruitment in the agriculture sector was adopted; it covers all workers in the agriculture sector, including migrants who are irregular workers and need protection. The reforms encompass labour protection, enforcement and exploitation prevention. The number of residence permits were increased for study reasons, special protection, religious reasons, calamities, elective residence, artistic activities and for persons awaiting citizenship. The maximum duration of granting Italian citizenship was reduced to 24 months.

In response to the pandemic situation, Italy took several measures to regularize foreign workers

who had been in the country before 8 March 2020. This involved issuing new contracts or a temporary residence permit (if a previous one had expired after October 2019) for citizens of non-European Union countries in agriculture, fisheries and related activities or in domestic work or caregiving services.

c. Labour demand and trends in Italy

The Italian economy consists of a few major economic sectors: services, manufacturing, construction and agriculture. In terms of employment status, the most general type of contract is fixed term and full-time appointments. The most required qualification in the labour market is an upper-secondary school diploma. Like many countries, the labour market is experiencing a quick improvement from the pandemic period. For instance, along with gross domestic product growth, there was an increased labour force participation rate and reduced unemployment rate and a reduction in the number of jobseekers in 2022. Due to the uncertainty of economic trends and supply of raw materials because of the war in Ukraine, some economic sectors have slowed their progress, such as manufacturing and construction. Services is remaining strong, along with the recovery of the tourism industry.

Thus, the 2022 forecast for labour demand revealed a requirement of 1,531,450 workers for the services sector (business, tourism, catering) and 322,400 new recruitments for the industry sector. The 2022 job demand were jobs that primarily required a secondary education qualification.¹⁵ Table 36 indicates the most difficult-to-recruit employment categories per each education level.

14 Source of information for this section: Claudia Finotelli, "Migration and migration policy in Italy", bpb, 4 April 2022; OECD, International Migration Outlook 2022, 2022; OECD, *International Migration Outlook 2021*, 2021.

15 EURES, "Italy Is Looking For You!", 2022.

Table 3.2. Most difficult-to-fill categories per each education attainment level in Italy, 2022

Tertiary level	Vocational level	Secondary level
• Dentistry • Health care • Paramedical • Mathematical • Physical • Computer science	• Textile and clothing • Motor vehicle repair • Electricians • Well-being sector	• Mechanics • Mechatronics • Energy • Electronics and electrical engineering • IT and telecommunications • Industrial and craft production and maintenance

Source: See European Job Days, “Italy”.

Table 37 highlights the sectors that may benefit from the Government’s push for the green economy concept and thus a higher demand to fill modern job opportunities (green jobs).

Table 3.3. Sectors in Italy that could generate high demand for workers with green economy skills

Construction sector

Sustainable architect

Designers of sustainable buildings

Installers of low environmental-impact air-conditioning systems; for mechanics

Experts in electric motor systems and/or component technologies; for the environment

Environmental IT specialists to develop environmental software and applications

Environmental lawyers, mobility managers, energy managers and eco-designers

Source: See Europa, “Labour Market Information: Italy”.

The Government’s forecasting for 2022–26 acknowledged that workers are needed: 40,000 ICT technicians; 30,000 mathematics and computer science specialists; 120,000–130,000 technicians in organizational and financial activities; 50,000 environmental engineers and architects; 220,000 workers specializing in construction and the maintenance of building structures and construction

finishers; and 25,000 construction engineers and technicians.¹⁶

In addition, the forecast emphasized the importance of reducing female unemployment, which was reportedly the highest among the Europe countries, at 9.9 per cent in 2021.¹⁷

¹⁶ Ibid

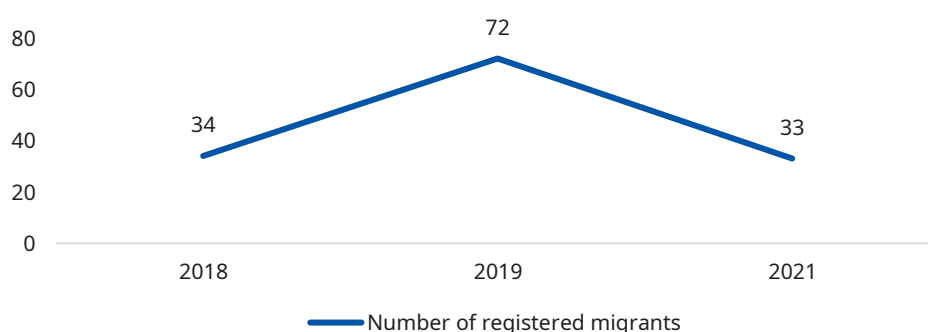
¹⁷ Ibid

d. Migration to Italy from Sri Lanka

Italy's latest Census statistics refer to 1,936 immigrants from Sri Lanka in 2021, with 915 men and 1,021 women. However, the Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment statistics contain only record of 33 Sri Lankan migrant workers in Italy in 2021, with

18 men and 13 women (figures 53 and 54). (Those same records showed 34 registered migrants in 2018 and 72 in 2019.) This emphasizes the need for Sri Lanka to increase the number of migrants to Italy and the importance of regular reliable data on the migrant outflow.

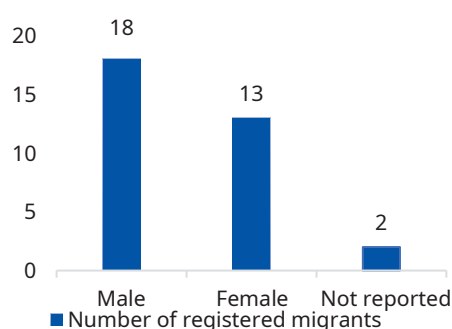
Figure 3.3. Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment-registered migrants in Italy, 2021



Source: Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment statistics, 2021.

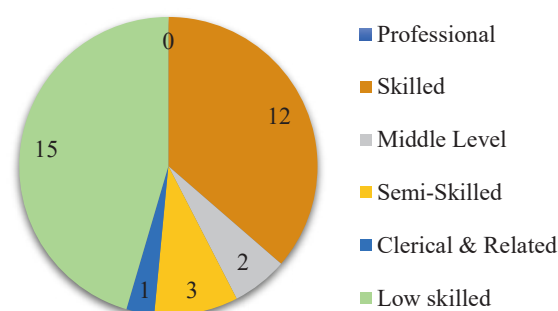
The few migrants registered with the Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment were in low-skilled jobs (figure 55).

Figure 3.4. Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment-registered migrants in Italy, by gender, 2021



Source: Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment statistics, 2021.

Figure 3.5. Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment-registered migrants in Italy, by skill category, 2021



According to KNOMAD's bilateral remittance matrix, Italy emerged in the top-ten of countries with a large remittance total to Sri Lanka, despite the few Sri Lankan migrants, at US\$264 million.¹⁸

On the Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment vacancies webpage, there are no available vacancies for Italy.¹⁹

¹⁸ KNOMAD, "Bilateral Remittance Matrix 2021", n.d.

¹⁹ SLBFE, "Foreign Job Vacancies", n.d.

Italian labour market demand

Recruitment pathways	Challenges and barriers	Skill gaps to be bridged	Visa process
Job opportunities are found through personal contacts, LinkedIn and job sites.	- Language barrier to converse fluently in Italian (required in workplaces) and English - Migrants working illegally as blue-collar workers without work permits	- Language proficiency in Italian - English language proficiency - Familiarity with advanced technology and digital skills - Flexibility and the ability to work in a team	The work visa is acquired through the employer. Nulla Osta and resident permit are necessary (proof of sufficient financial means also required). Student visa is possible for postgraduate and master's degree programmes at Italian universities. Students are provided a work visa upon completion of their study programme. Students are allowed to work part-time while studying. There are 2 types of student visas, depending on the duration of the study programme: (i) visa type C, for short-stay or travel, which is valid for one or more entries and for a period not exceeding 90 days and (ii) visa type D, for long stays, which is valid for more than 90 days.

Immediate and mid-term opportunities, 1-2 years			
Job category	Required qualifications (acceptance for local qualifications)		Work experience
Professional and skilled Hospitality sector: food and beverage, hotel management, housekeeping skills related opportunities, chef and waiter, catering services; food preparation, cooking and distribution worker Health sector: nurse and caregiver Operational support services for businesses, transport, logistics and warehousing services Construction sector: civil engineer, architect IT sector: software engineer Hairstylist in salons	Qualifications for professional and skilled categories <i>(Italian language skills are preferred for all job categories.)</i> Sri Lankan academic qualifications and professional qualifications are recognized. Applicants can have degrees from German Tech or technical colleges or related vocational training qualifications for skilled and semi-skilled jobs (NVQ levels 4-7). Hotel management school qualifications for the hotel sector is essential.		Minimum work experience of 3-5 years is required for the professional and skilled categories. Past experience in a similar capacity for handling the responsibilities is expected. Low-skilled delivery jobs do not require work experience.
Semi-skilled – industrial Transport and logistics: heavy vehicle truck driver, forklift driver, taxi driver, driver of cars, vans Construction: stone, brick, fire-brick mason, metal structure fitter, machine toolmaker Electrician in civil construction and similar professions Operator of automatic and semi-automatic industrial machine tools Industrial machinery mechanic and fitter and similar professions Worker assigned to industrial product packaging machines Installer and repairer of electrical and electromechanical equipment Plumber, water and gas pipe installer Low-skilled Delivery of goods	Nursing applicants must have a degree or diploma in nursing and the Sri Lanka nursing registration are required. A certificate course in caregiving is needed for the adult caregivers. A IELTS high score and Italian language proficiency are essential.		

Long-term opportunities, 3-5 years	
Hospitality sector: accommodation and catering service, food and beverage manager, chef, steward, waiter Health care assistants, nurse, caregiver Semi-skilled jobs in construction, heavy-vehicle driver Low-skilled workers: delivery of goods, domestic helper for child care	

*There will be 450,000 job openings for 2023-25 through the migration policy changes in Italy. The most common type of employment contract on offer is for a fixed term and full time (55.5 per cent). The qualification most requested is an upper-secondary school diploma.

Italian labour market demand

Sector	Skill category	Occupation category	Education and Skill requirements	Time period	Comments	Salary benefits
Information technology	Skilled, professional	ICT technician Mathematics and computer science specialist	Applicants must have a bachelor's degree in technical field, 5 years plus experience in the relevant field and language proficiency in English.	2022-26	As much as 49 per cent of vacancies remain unfilled	Professional and skilled jobs earn €45,000 upwards per annum. Semi-skilled jobs earn €24,000 upwards per annum.
Organizational and financial activities	Semi-skilled labour	Technician	Applicants must have advanced technical skills and other personal skills, such as problem-solving, troubleshooting and time management.	2022-26	Required skill set includes business and management skills	*Average wages in Italy increased to €2,627 per month (US\$2,861) in 2022. The maximum rate of average wage for employees was €2,502 per month and the minimum was €1,176 per month in 2022.
Environment	Skilled, professional	Environmental engineer Environmental IT specialist Environmental lawyer Mobility manager Energy manager Eco-designer Expert in electric motor systems	Applicants must have a relevant degree or professional qualification, field work experience in the relevant sector, strong communication and language skills and proficiency in MS office package.	2022-26	This is a high demand sector at global level and requires national level efforts to increase supply	For part-time student workers, the minimum per hour wage is €7. They can work a maximum of 4 hours a day and 20 hours a week. This will allow them to earn up to €140 a week and €560 a month.
Sustainable architect	Skilled, professional	Architect Designer of sustainable building	Applicants must have an accredited degree in a relevant field, proficiency in relevant design software, industry experience in similar capacity (3-5 years) and skills in team-playing, writing and verbal presenting in English.	2022-26	This is a high-demand sector at the global level and requires national-level efforts to increase supply.	

Italian labour market demand

Sector	Skill category	Occupation category	Education and Skill requirements	Time period	Comments	Salary benefits
Construction and the maintenance	Low-skilled labour	Labourer Construction finisher	Not specified	2022–26	Initiate some awareness programmes to divert some of the low-skilled migrant workers to Italy.	
	Skilled, semi-skilled, professional	Construction engineer and technician	Applicants must have an accredited degree or professional qualification in a relevant field. They should have skills in communication, problem-solving, troubleshooting, time management, English language and information technology.	2022–26	Initiate some awareness programmes to divert some of the low-skilled migrant workers to Italy.	
Mechanics	Semi-skilled labour	Installers of low environmental impact air-conditioning systems	Applicants must have a secondary school education in a technical field, 5 years of experience in the field of maintenance services or related area and working knowledge in English as well as computer skills.	2022–26	It is worth concentrating on this segment because the supply of workers can be increased within a short period.	

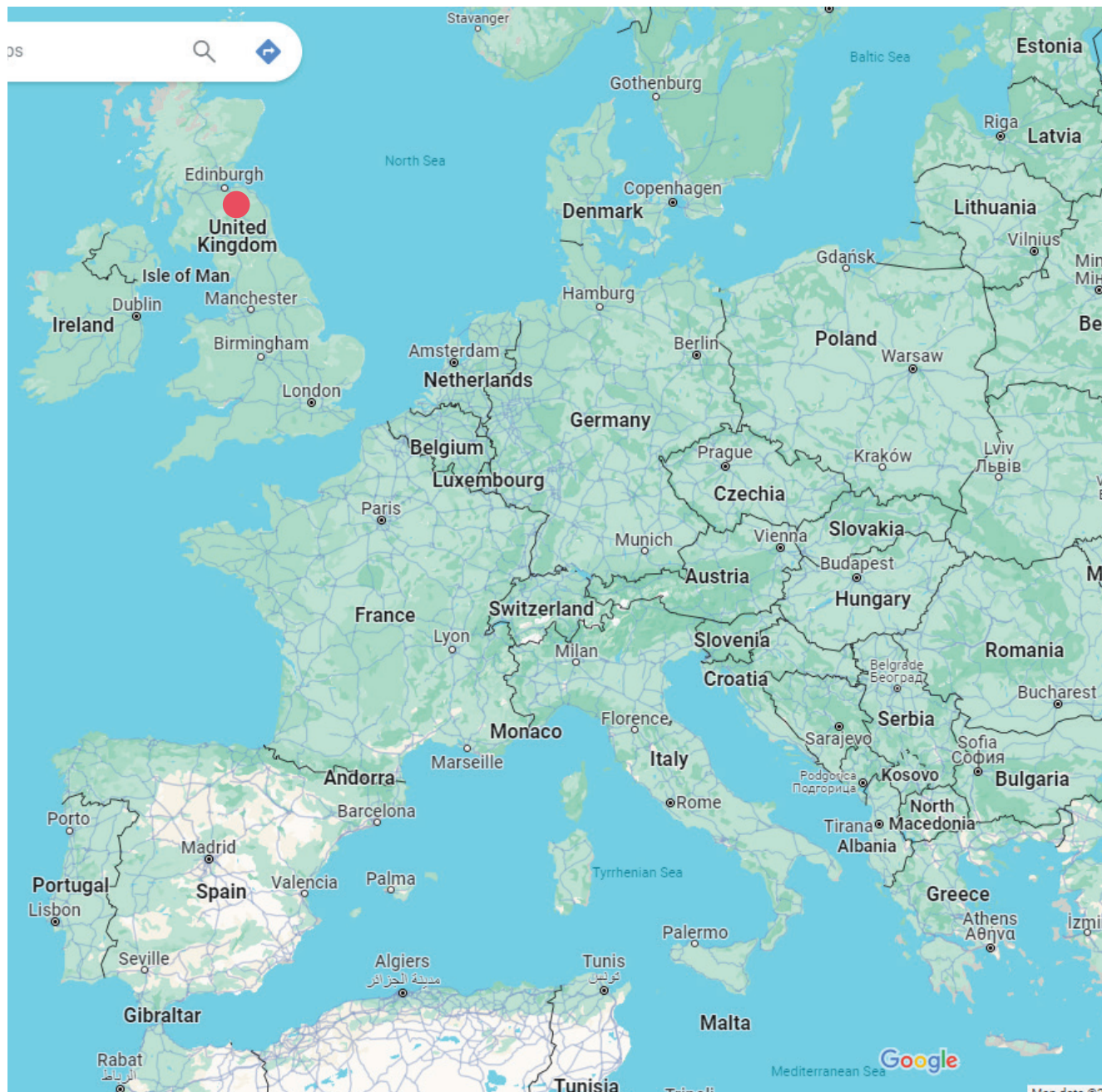
Recommendations for Italy

Key messages

- High demand for migrant workers in Italy e.g., migrant workers account for 8 per cent of the population.
- Estimated demand for migrant workers: 450,000 job openings for 2023–25.
- Most available job opportunities are in hotels, restaurants, cafes, construction, salons, health care and IT.

Recommendations

- Jobs for skilled and semi-skilled migrants should be targeted, especially ICT technicians, environment engineers and energy managers.
- With language a major barrier, public–private partnerships should be set up and encouraged to provide short-term courses that cater to the different language needs, including Italian.
- Italy is a very popular place to migrate to, and many people go through an illegal route. The Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment should initiate a formal route, such as what it has done for the Middle East, for interested individuals to access Italy for job opportunities. The formal access will minimize those who enter Italy illegally.
 - a. Encourage foreign employment agencies to set up links to send people in accordance with rules and regulations specific to Italy, for available job opportunities.
 - b. Initiate a government-to-government agreement to identify the calibre of skills that can be sent from Sri Lanka.
 - c. Because Sri Lankan academic qualifications and professional qualifications are accepted for many jobs, there is an opportunity to send high-calibre professionals.
- Italian language training should be provided at the technical colleges, with short courses offered through the Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment for spoken language.
- Demand-side information should be made available through country-specific job portals. Currently, job opportunities are found through personal contacts, LinkedIn and job sites.



United Kingdom

► Background

4. United Kingdom

a. Migrant population in the United Kingdom

The United Kingdom emerged seventh in the scoring system used for this study, with a large migrant population of migrants from many countries and as a top source of remittances to Sri Lanka. Only a few Sri Lankans in the United Kingdom, however, were registered with the Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment.

According to OECD statistics, 14 per cent of the population in the United Kingdom in 2019 was foreign born.²⁰ The total migrant population in the United Kingdom in 2020 was 9,359,587, with more women than men (figure 26). Among the migrant population, the largest portion was aged 20–64 in 2020 (figure 27).

Figure 4.1. International migrants in the United Kingdom, by gender, 2020

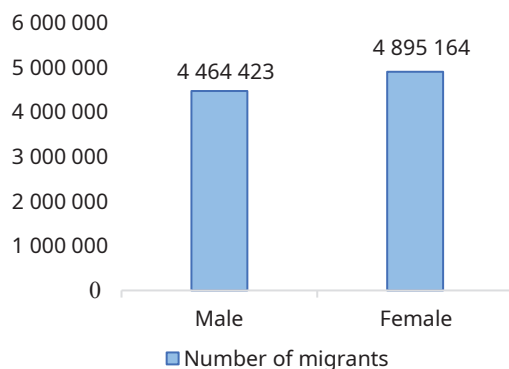
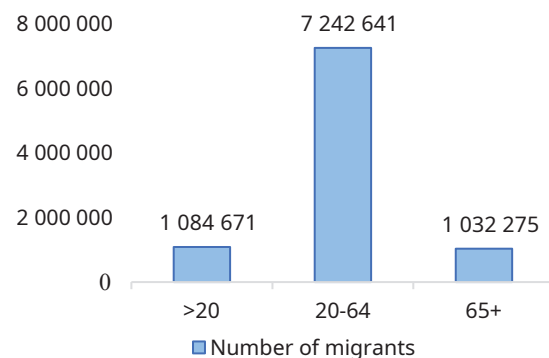


Figure 4.2. International migrants in the United Kingdom, by age, 2020



Source: UN DESA, Population Division, “International Migration Stock 2020”.

According to OECD data 2022, 79.9 per cent of the labour force participants in 2021 in the United Kingdom were foreign born, with the foreign-born employment rate at 75.5 per cent. Both rates were

higher than the average rates in 2021 for OECD countries as average labour force participants rate was 75.7 per cent while average foreign-born employment rate was 69.2 per cent.²¹

²⁰ OECD, International Migration Outlook 2022, 2022.

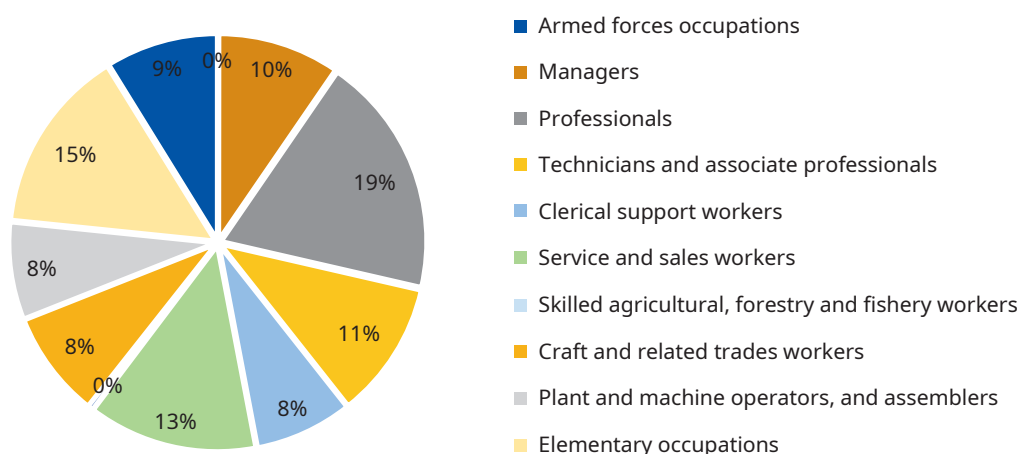
²¹ Ibid

The United Kingdom's 2012 Labour Force Survey findings indicate that the finance, retail and health sectors have comprised a greater proportion of international migrants than persons born in the country.²² Figure 28 depicts the economically active foreign-born population by occupation, according to the 2011 Census data,²³ with the largest portion of foreign-born people employed as professionals, followed by elementary occupations.

As stated in a 2022 press release from the University of Oxford, by the third quarter 2021, foreign-born

employees in the United Kingdom constituted 18 per cent of the total employed population. More migrant men were likely to be employed than men born in the United Kingdom, although fewer migrant women were less likely to be employed than women born there. Migrants born in Pakistan and other South Asian countries (with the exception of India) were heavily represented in the retail and transport and storage sectors.

Figure 4.3. Percentage of foreign-born population in the United Kingdom, by occupation, 2011



Source: UN DESA, "Economically Active Foreign-born Population by Occupation, Age, Sex and Urban/Rural Residence", 2011 (latest available data).

According to International Organization for Migration data, the top-five migrant-sending countries to the United Kingdom in 2020 were Poland, India, Pakistan, Romania and Ireland (table 18).

Table 4.1. Top-five migrant-sending countries to the United Kingdom, 2020

Country	Migrant population
Poland	835 975
India	835 359
Pakistan	537 047
Romania	393 569
Ireland	370 151

Source: IOM, *World Migration Report 2022*, 2022.

²² Government of United Kingdom, Immigration and the UK Labour Market: The Latest Evidence from Economic Research, 2012.

²³ The data cover the United Kingdom of Great Britain and Northern Ireland, excluding the Channel Islands (Guernsey and Jersey) and Isle of Man as per the data source.

b. Migration policy in the United Kingdom²⁴

The United Kingdom introduced a point-based immigration system that took effect in January 2021. The most important thing is that the system treats European Union citizens and non-European Union nationals alike – all require a visa to enter the United Kingdom. According to the Government, the European Union’s free movement system was failing to meet the needs of the United Kingdom as well as failing to provide benefits to highly skilled migrants from other regions willing to migrate to and serve its economy. The Government implemented the new system with the objective of expanding its migration system to serve all foreign-born residents in an equal way. The Government believes this adaptation will revolutionize the operation of its borders, tighten security and deliver a better “customer” experience for migrants coming to the United Kingdom.

This system is expected to provide more opportunities to skilled foreign workers who can contribute the most to the economy. The objective of the new system is to end free movement and change the long-term work route, which is now called the “skilled-worker route”, to focus on highly skilled or semi-skilled foreign workers. To obtain a skilled worker visa, applicants must have the required points based on certain criteria, such as a job offer from an approved sponsor, a job at an appropriate skill level, English language skills, etc. The required points for each applicant vary based on the job, applicant’s skill level, the salary and so on.

As explained in the OECD’s International Migration Outlook 2022, the new policy implications include adaptation of the digital control system, which makes the recruitment of foreigners for skilled jobs more flexible and covers national labour shortages. The policy also includes new routes for economic

workers, such as health and caregiving workers and new graduates. Changes to the quota-based seasonal worker visas include a temporary extension, a scaled-up route (in effect since mid-2022), adaptation of special reforms for the resettlement of Afghan citizens, adoption of the Nationality and Borders Act, 2022 that prevents illegal entry and targets smuggling networks and country-specific agreements with Rwanda (a new Migration and Economic Development Partnership) and Ukraine regarding refugees and their families affected by the war. Additionally, high-growth companies are now able to sponsor workers in high-skill roles.

c. Labour demand and trends in the United Kingdom²⁵

A study published by the Government on The Future of Work – Jobs and Skills 2030 cited 13 trends as the most influential on the direction of jobs and skills (table 19). The study’s findings highlight that more than one third of economically active people are aged 65 or older. The findings also note the increase of virtual workers globally, that the majority of business innovations in the future will be co-developed with partners outside the business and that advanced manufacturing processes could lead to employment increases in the manufacturing sector. The study findings also stress actions for protecting the future job market from challenges, such as job losses due to digitalization, automation of professional work, artificial intelligence and robots. The suggested actions refer to increasing workforce diversity, encouraging individuals to take greater responsibility for investing in their own skills and developing technological skills and calling on policymakers to devise a strategy that ensures low-skilled labour adaptation to the changing labour market.

24 Source for the information in this section: Government of United Kingdom, “The UK’s Points-based Immigration System: Policy Statement”, 19 February 2020; OECD, *International Migration Outlook 2022*, 2022.

25 Source for the information for this section: Government of United Kingdom, *The Future of Work: Jobs and Skills in 2030*, 2014; Ann Morris, *Shortage Occupation List 2023*, 4 October 2023; Government of United Kingdom, *Immigration Rules – Immigration Rules Appendix Shortage Occupation List - Guidance*, 2016; CIPD, *Labour Market Outlook: Spring 2023*

Table 4.2. The 13 trends with great influence on jobs and skills in the United Kingdom, to 2030

Society and the individual	Technology and innovation	Business and the economy	Resources and the environment	Law and politics
• Changing work environments • Growing diversity • Desire for • Work-life balance • Demographic change • Income uncertainty	• Converging technology • ICT and big data • Digitalization of production	• Changed economic perspectives • New business ecosystems • Shift to Asia	• Growing scarcity of resources	• Decreasing scope for political action

Source: Government of United Kingdom, *The Future of Work: Jobs and Skills in 2030*, 2014.

The Government publishes a regularly updated Shortage Occupation List on the most important industry gaps that the United Kingdom needs to fill with high-skilled professionals, wherever they may originate. The list provides information on

eligible job opportunities for skilled worker visas that applicants can apply for. For instance, table 20 shows the ten occupations with vacancies listed as of June 2023.

Table 4.3. Top-ten shortage occupations in the United Kingdom, as of June 2023

1181	Health services and public health managers and directors – all jobs
1242	Residential, day and domiciliary care managers and proprietors – all jobs
2111	Chemical scientists – only jobs in the nuclear industry
2112	Biological scientists and biochemists – all jobs
2113	Physical scientists – only the following jobs in the construction-related ground engineering industry: engineering geologist, hydrogeologist, geophysicist
2113	Physical scientists – only the following jobs in the oil and gas industry: geophysicist, geoscientist, geologist, geochemist, technical services manager in the decommissioning and waste areas of the nuclear industry, senior resource geologist and staff geologist in the mining sector
2114	Social and humanities scientists – only archaeologist
2121	Civil engineers – all jobs
2122	Mechanical engineers – all jobs
2123	Electrical engineers – all jobs

Source: Immigration Rules Appendix, Shortage Occupation List.

A recent survey of employers in the United Kingdom by the Chartered Institute of Personnel and Development revealed that by the spring of 2023, employment intentions remained positive in all industries.²⁶ The predicted recruitments will be highest in the construction sector with a few novel occupations likely added to the Shortage Occupation List, such as bricklayers, roofers, carpenters and plasterers. The survey report stressed that employers in the United Kingdom can access a wider pool of suitable workers due to the more favourable migration arrangements, including the recent reforms of the system.

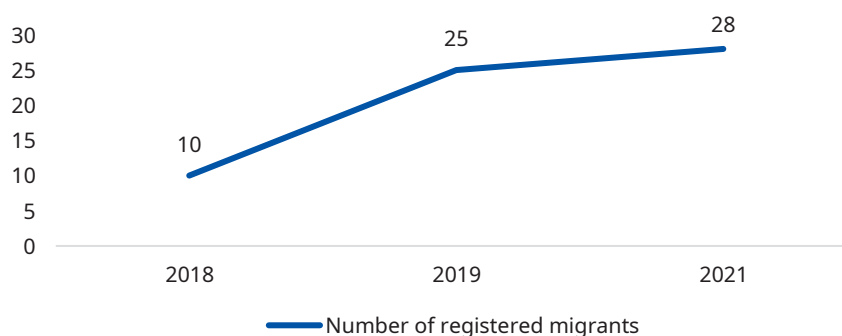
The survey report also highlighted that the education and health sectors are struggling to fill their vacancies. More than half of the surveyed employers in each industry reported a struggle to fill their vacancies, and 16 per cent of the surveyed employers need to fill their vacancies with non-European Union citizens.

In response to a recommendation from the Migration Advisory Committee in the United Kingdom, the Government announced that jobs in the seafood sector, such as fisherfolk, trawler skippers and experienced deckhands on large vessels, will be added to the Shortage Occupation List as of May 2023.

d. Migration to the United Kingdom from Sri Lanka

According to Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment statistics, only 28 Sri Lankans registered as migrant workers in the United Kingdom in 2021. In 2018, there were ten registered migrants and 25 in 2019 (figure 29). Of the 28 registered migrants, four were women, and most of them were classified as professionals (figures 30 and 31). These statistics emphasize the importance of rethinking a novel approach regarding the United Kingdom to capitalize on the opportunities in their labour market.

Figure 4.4. Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment-registered migrants in the United Kingdom, 2018, 2019 and 2021



Source: Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment statistics, 2021.

26 CIPD, *Labor Market Outlook – Views from Employers*, 2023.

Figure 4.5. Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment-registered migrants in the United Kingdom, by gender, 2021

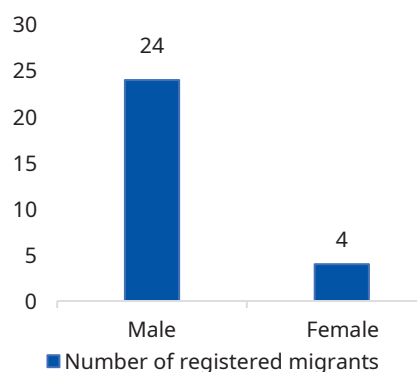
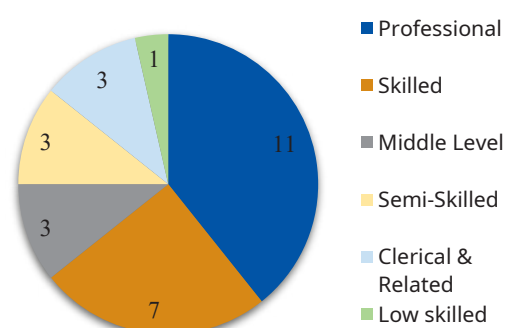


Figure 4.6. Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment-registered migrants in the United Kingdom, by skill level, 2021



Source: Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment statistics, 2021.

According to KNOMAD’s bilateral remittance matrix, the United Kingdom was among the top-six countries for Sri Lanka remittances in 2021, at US\$359 million.²⁷

On the Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment’s vacancies page, there are eight types of job

categories for the United Kingdom, and most of them are in the health and caregiving sector, with 596 vacancies – 485 of which remain unfilled.²⁸

²⁷ KNOMAD, “Bilateral Remittance Matrix 2021”, n.d.

²⁸ SLBFE, “Foreign Job Vacancies”, n.d.

United Kingdom labour market demand

Recruitment pathways	Challenges and barriers	Skill gaps to be bridged	Visa process
Job opportunities found in LinkedIn, web searches, personal contacts, migration consultants and British job agents.	- Lack of fluency in English to converse - Migrant workers from African countries and neighbouring Eastern European countries get more opportunities due to their language fluency - Nurses offered lower-scale jobs at residential homes and nursing homes as community caregivers until they obtain a Nursing and Midwifery Council certificate to become a nursing officer - Some employers require shadowing period of 3 months - Work permit hours are reduced by some agents deviating from the agreement	- Language proficiency in (English) - Soft skills (skills in customer care, mannerisms) - Driver's license (All domiciliary care workers need to visit homes. Sri Lanka driver's license is valid only for one year period until the British license is obtained.)	Work visa directly arranged by the employer. Applicants for student and job visa can migrate to the country along with spouse and family through dependant visa category. Student visa is available for post-graduate studies in British universities. Student visa applicants are allowed to work 20 hours per week, as are dependants. * Mostly find jobs in hospitality industry, hotels and restaurants. Visit visa and dependant visa offered to only the immediate relatives for short stays.

Immediate and mid-term opportunities, 1-2 years		
Job category	Required qualifications (acceptance for local qualifications)	Work experience
Professional and skilled Health sector: medical doctor, dentist, pharmacist, nurse and adult caregiver IT-related: software engineer, system developer	Qualifications for medical professionals and health sector-skilled employees. Sri Lankan academic and professional qualifications related to medical (Bachelor of Medicine, Bachelor of Surgery) and postgraduate, degree or diploma level for health professionals are recognized. To become eligible to work as a medical doctor, a degree in medicine recognized by the General Medical Council, which takes 5 years, a foundation course of general training, which takes 2 years, specialist training, which can take between 5 and 8 years depending on the specialty.	Minimum work experience of 3-5 years for all professional and skilled categories.
Skilled and semi-skilled Hospitality sector: chef in hotels and restaurants		Certificates related to work experience add more points during the evaluation in addition to the academic or professional qualifications.
Low-skilled <i>Low-skilled jobs are not offered to Sri Lankan migrant workers. These are filled mostly through eastern European country migrant workers (Romania, Poland, Czech Republic).</i> <i>*Opportunities for female nurses than male</i> <i>*Other professions equal opportunity given for both gender</i>		Sri Lankan experienced nurses of the government sector with high IELTS score band are generally absorbed to the National Health Service of England.

United Kingdom labour market demand

Immediate and mid-term opportunities, 1–2 years		
Job category	Required qualifications (acceptance for local qualifications)	Work experience
	To pursue postgraduate studies, an individual must register with the General Medical Council. To practise medicine, an applicant must hold a registration with a license to practise. Holding a license allows, for example, prescribing medicine and treating patients. To work as a nurse, an applicant must have a degree or diploma in nursing and must be registered with the Nursing and Midwifery Council. There are four nursing specialisms (adult, children, mental health and learning disability) Should take the Academic Module for Nursing and Midwifery Council registration, along with the IELTS for UK visas and immigration. The test consists of listening, reading, writing and speaking components, with 9 the highest score possible in each category. The Nursing and Midwifery Council overall score and all subtests except for writing as 6.5 is acceptable. A certificate course in caregiving for the adult caregivers or nurses is required to obtain a Nursing and Midwifery Council certification within 6 months to 1 year period. IT professional applicants must have a local or foreign bachelor's degree programmes in ICT-related postgraduate studies. Chef applicants must have a technical college or hotel school of management or related vocational training qualifications (NVQ levels 4–7). Language proficiency requires an IELTS score above 7; high fluency in English is a must for all applicants.	Students have to submit an IELTS score to get admission to nursing colleges in the United Kingdom minimum of 6.5 or above. Others could work as a care assistant to gain experience for 6 months – one year and get the Nursing and Midwifery Council certification to become a nurse in the United Kingdom. Medical and health professionals find more opportunities in the United Kingdom as Sri Lankan professionals are highly recognized in England due to their skills, competency and commitment to work.

Long-term opportunities, 3–5 years
Health sector: nurse, caregiver for ageing population (Since the ageing population in UK on the rise, there will be opportunities continued for health professionals, such as nurses and caregivers.) IT sector: software engineer in cyber security Hotel and restaurant sector: food and beverage, housekeeping

* There will be a policy change in the United Kingdom in 2024 regarding imposing of restrictions on the dependant visa category for students.

United Kingdom labour market demand

Sector	Skill category	Occupation category	Education and Skill requirements	Time period	Comments	Salary benefits
Construction	Low-skilled	Bricklayer Roofer Carpenter Plasterer	Applicants must have a minimum of 1 year of experience, a basic set of skills in most construction disciplines, driver's license or Construction Skills Certification Scheme for bricklayers and plasters, advanced carpentry skills for carpenters. Relevant certifications or apprenticeships in plastering is preferred.	Predicted to be included in the Shortage Occupation List		For full-time workers, the average salary in 2022 was £33,000. Part-time employees earned an average of £12,247 in 2022. Medical doctor and IT professional salary ranges from £50,000 to £280,000 per annum. The basic pay for a registered nurse ranges from £22,816 to £28,407 a year, for a 37.5-hour week.
Seafood	Low-skilled	Fisherfolk Trawler skipper Experienced deckhand	Applicants must have skills in safe navigation of the vessel, maintaining the vessel to a high standard and using fishing technique. Experience in a similar role is preferred. A relevant certification for skippers and deckhands, such as RYA/MCA/STCW (yacht master) certification, medical and first aid certificate are essential.		Training and experience in fisherfolk role can lead to career growth as a skipper or marine engineer	
Health services	Skilled, professional	Public health manager and director	Applicants must have experience in management or leadership in the relevant sector or a relevant professional qualification.	In the Shortage Occupation List in 2023, and demand for these jobs are expected in the next few years too.	Potential market if equipped with work experience and fluent in English	
Nuclear Industry	Skilled, professional	Chemical scientist	Applicants must have a bachelor's, master's or PhD degree in chemistry or related disciplines, industry and research experience.			
Domiciliary care services	Skilled, semi-skilled, professional	Residential, day and domiciliary care manager and proprietor	Applicants must have a certificate of higher education in relevant field (health, social care management), at least 1 year of experience and skills in team management.		Potential market if equipped with work experience and fluent in English	

United Kingdom labour market demand

Sector	Skill category	Occupation category	Education and Skill requirements	Time period	Comments	Salary benefits
Biological	Skilled, professional	Biological scientist Biochemist	Applicants must have a bachelor's or master's degree in biological sciences, chemistry or relevant field or scientific discipline, industrial or laboratory experience and research, computer literacy.		Potential market	
Construction-related ground engineering industry	Skilled, professional	Engineering Geologist Hydrogeologist Geophysicist	Applicants must have a bachelor's degree or master's in engineering, geoscience, earth sciences, geology, hydrology, hydrogeology, relevant sector experience, with skills in written and verbal communication.		Potential market	
Oil and gas industry	Skilled, professional	Geophysicist Geoscientist Geologist Geochemist Technical services manager in the decommissioning and waste areas of the nuclear industry Senior resource geologist Staff geologist in the mining sector	Applicants must have a bachelor's or master's degree in geosciences, earth sciences, geology, hydrology, hydrogeology, relevant sector experience, with skills in written and verbal communication.			
Social and humanities	Skilled, professional	Archaeologist	Applicants must have a degree in archaeology or a related discipline, knowledge of relevant lab techniques and methods, with skills in time management, planning, etc. and field work experience.			
Engineering	Skilled, professional	Civil engineer Mechanical engineer Electrical engineer	Applicants must have a bachelor's or advanced degree (master's) in engineering field, experience similar engineering roles, a detailed oriented mindset, critical thinking and problem-solving skills.		Potential very high	

United Kingdom labour market demand

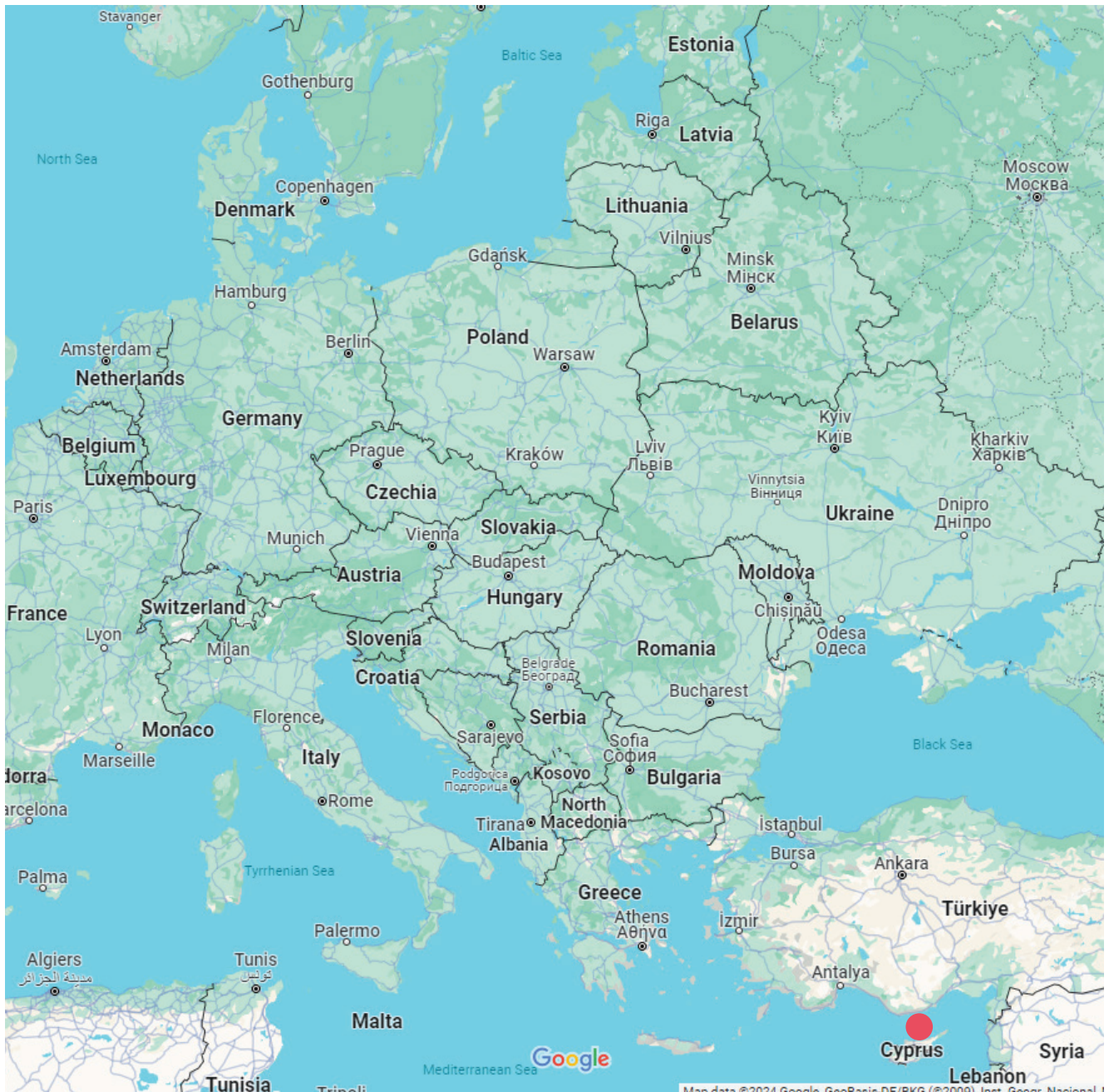
Recommendations for United Kingdom and Ireland

Key messages

- There is high demand in the United Kingdom for medical and health professionals, IT and hospitality sector occupations; while in Ireland it is for medical and health professionals, IT, chemical, biomedical, automobile and energy engineers, business and finance, transport and logistics and the hospitality sector.
- There is a high level of unfilled vacancies in the United Kingdom. After the pandemic, the United Kingdom has seen an unprecedented increase in work visas granted. The economy is suffering from a labour shortage, with an estimated 1 million vacancies, which is 300,000 more than before the pandemic. In the short term, the United Kingdom has high potential for new migration opportunities.
- Wages and benefits are highly attractive, at £22,816–£28,407 a year for a nurse.
- In the medium and long term, health care workers have the highest potential for finding employment. The United Kingdom has a separate visa category for health care workers and publishes a separate list of shortage professions for this category.
- UK Visas and Immigration is a division of the Home Office, which is responsible for the visas and immigration system, at www.gov.uk/government/organisations/uk-visas-and-immigration.
- A batch of 300 nurses were interviewed for jobs, but only three of them were selected due to their poor language skills.

Recommendations

- Professional and semi-skilled migration should be a concentrated focus.
- English language proficiency is a mandatory requirement for all categories of employees, who are required to pass the language proficiency test in English. Therefore, initiate public private partnerships to polish up language skills of the aspiring candidates. Along with the language skills, soft skills, communication skills, how to face interviews, etiquette and work ethics should also be included.
- Currently the most prominent pathways for work in the United Kingdom for Sri Lankans are either informal or personal. The graduate worker stream is used mostly for migration to the United Kingdom. Those who migrate directly for jobs use LinkedIn or personal pathways. Therefore, a system to connect the potential workers to opportunities must be established.
- Mutually beneficial migration should continue through bilateral labour agreements.
- Information sessions should be organized on job market prospects and application procedures, qualification and experience requirements and other entry requirements for the United Kingdom and Ireland.



Cyprus

Cyprus labour market demand

Recruitment pathways	Challenges and barriers	Skill gaps to be bridged	Salary benefits	Visa process
Job opportunities found through agents and the Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment website.	- Lack of English fluency to converse - Use of advanced technology	English language proficiency	Domestic worker minimum salary is €350 per month.	The work visa is provided through the employer for a 2-year contract.

Immediate and mid-term opportunities, 1–2 years		
Job category	Required qualifications (acceptance for local qualifications)	Work experience
Skilled and semi-skilled Caregiver Hotel management (waiter, cook, bartender, baker) Domestic worker	Applicants must have a diploma in nursing or a certificate course in caregiving for the adult caregivers from German Tech, technical colleges or related vocational training qualifications (NVQ levels 4–7). And they should have a skill assessment test score.	Minimum work experience of 1–2 years is required in skilled categories in similar capacity.

Long-term opportunities, 3–5 years
Adult caregiver Hotel management Domestic worker

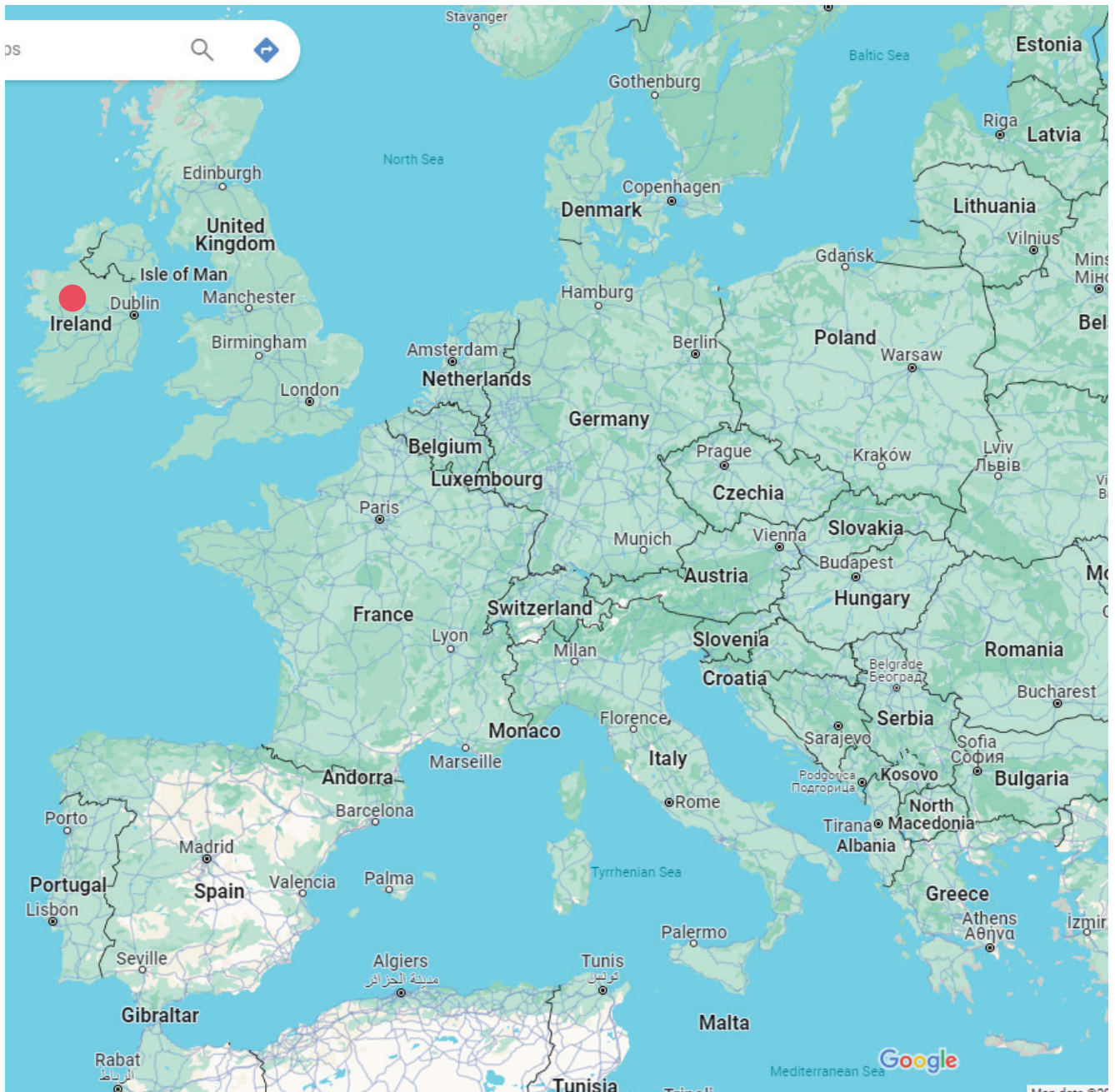
Recommendations for Cyprus

Key messages

- Caregiver and hospitality are two important sectors for Sri Lanka to promote migration in Cyprus.
- Fluency in English and Greek or Turkish are strong positive factors.
- Most opportunities are for blue-collar, skilled and semi-skilled jobs like caregivers, hotel staff and domestic workers.

Recommendations

- The formal pathway should be enhanced by the Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment for aspiring migrants to access jobs in Cyprus.
- Public-private partnerships should be initiated to provide language courses for aspiring migrants to attend before departing for Cyprus.
- Knowledge in handling technology and equipment in the workplace (video demos) should be provided.



Republic of Ireland

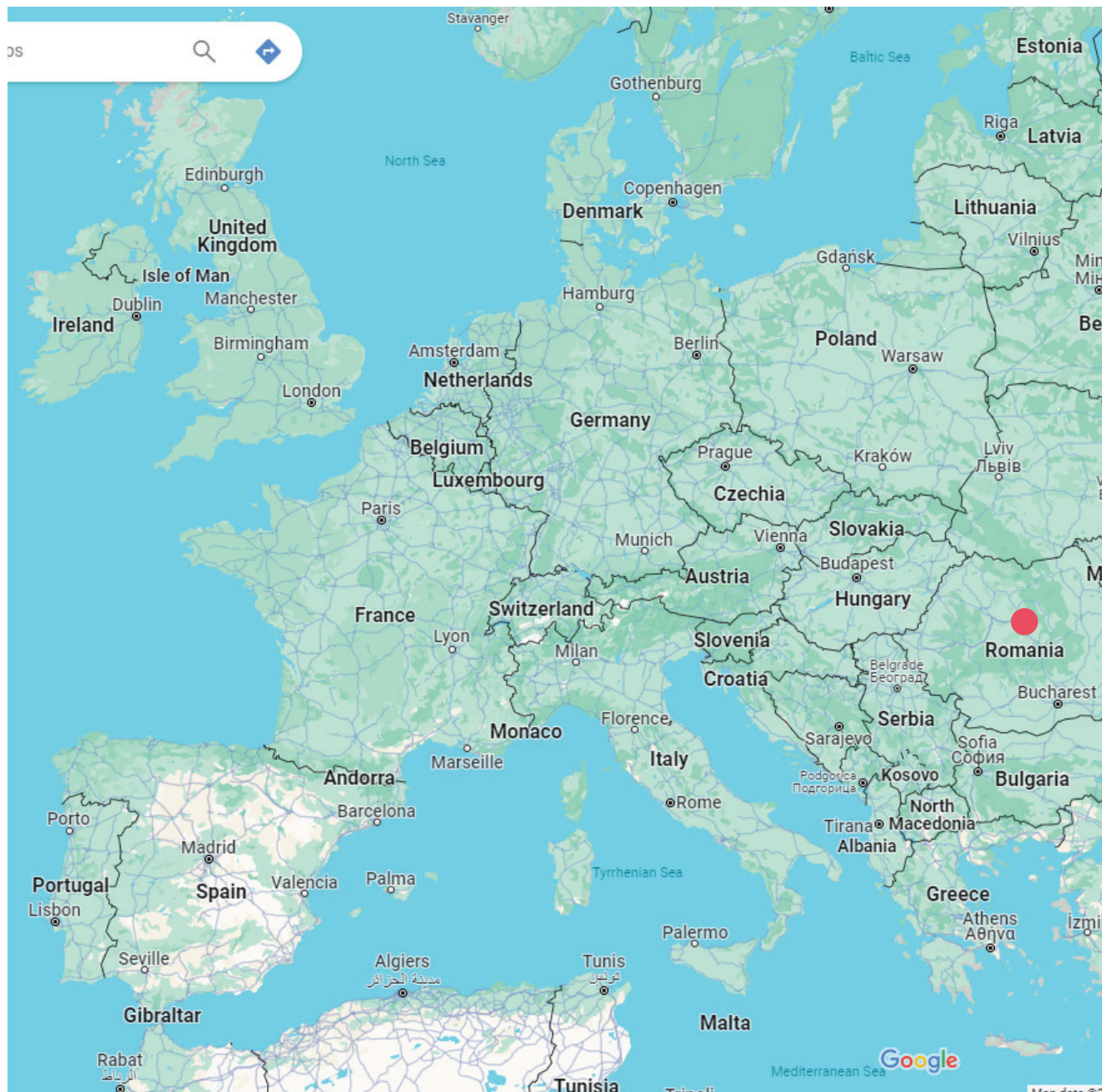
Republic of Ireland labour market demand

Recruitment pathways	Challenges and barriers	Skill gaps to be bridged	Visa process	Recommendations
Job opportunities are found through personal contacts and LinkedIn. <i>*Non-European Union citizens require work visa through recruitment agencies.</i>	- Lack of fluency in English to converse - Supply of labour from neighbouring countries, such as eastern Europe - Essential requirements for medical professionals and nursing jobs to register with Irish Medical Council	- Language proficiency in (English) - Soft skills (all jobs) - Skills in customer care, teamwork	There are several visa options: Short stay of 90 days, long stay and re-entry students and job visa seekers can migrate with spouse and family through dependent visa. Work visa are obtained directly through employers and personal contacts. Student visa applicants apply through universities. Students are allowed to work 20 hours per week. The long stay D visa is for those intending to live and work in Ireland. These include study, employment, join a family member and volunteer visas.	- English language skills development programmes should be available at the universities and colleges. - Job-specific training must be updated with the technological advancements in overseas. - Knowledge in handling of technological devices used in overseas countries should be given to all the applicants prior departure. For instance, the training given for housekeeping has to be updated with know-how to use the equipment.

Immediate and mid-term opportunities, 1-2 years			
Job category	Required qualifications (acceptance for local qualifications)	Work experience	Work experience
Professional and skilled Specialist, registrar, consultant doctor in multiple specialties: emergency medicine, paediatrics, general medicine, anaesthesia, obstetrics and gynaecology, family medicine, psychiatry	For medical professionals and health care-related jobs, the Sri Lankan academic and professional qualifications related to medical (Bachelor of Medicine, Bachelor of Surgery) and postgraduate, degree, diploma level for health professionals accepted and recognized.	Minimum work experience of 3-5 years is required for all professional and skilled categories.	Salaries range from £47,000 to £70,000 per annum for professional and skilled employees.
Health care: nurse, radiologist and pharmacist Engineering: chemical engineer, biomedical engineer, automobile and energy engineer IT software engineering: data analyst, programmer and IT support specialist, cyber security Business and finance: financial adviser, accountant and risk and compliance professional Transport and logistics: supply chain manager and analyst and transport manager Hospitality: chef, restaurant staff	Applicants must have diploma in nursing and Sri Lanka nursing registration. A certificate course in caregiving for adult caregivers. Relevant clinical experience (relevant post-qualification experience and training) and excellent communication skills and IELTS or Occupational English Test if applicable are expected. Sri Lankan academic and professional qualifications related to electrical engineering mechanical or civil engineering are recognized. Applicants must have a degree, postgraduate degree or higher national diploma level for software engineering.	Work experience certificates in the similar capacity or field are highly recognized and given more weightage during the selection process.	
<i>* There are no opportunities available for low-skilled workers.</i>			

Republic of Ireland labour market demand

Immediate and mid-term opportunities, 1-2 years			
Job category	Required qualifications (acceptance for local qualifications)	Work experience	Work experience
	Business and finance applicants must have a degree or postgraduate degree in finance, management or accounting or be chartered or be Chartered Institute of Management Accountants-qualified. Transport and logistics applicants must have a degree or postgraduate degree in supply chain management or logistics. Hospitality applicants must have a Ceylon Hotel School or any other private hotel school qualification as a chef, with work experience in a hotel chain.		
Long-term opportunities, 3-5 years			
IT professional			
Nurse, adult caregiver			
Green energy engineer, automobile engineer			



Romaina

Romania labour market demand

Recruitment pathways	Challenges and barriers	Skill gaps to be bridged	Visa process
Job opportunities are found through the MOU with the Romanian Government, the foreign employment agencies and foreign employment agents.	- Language barrier due to the need to converse fluently in English - Competition from migrant workers from Poland, Croatia, Philippines and India in Romania due to low-cost labour and language proficiency in English	- Language proficiency in English - Knowledge of technology used in the country	Work visa is acquired through the employer for a 2-year contract period. This process is coordinated by the Ministry of Health.

Immediate and mid-term opportunities, 1-2 years			
Job category	Required qualifications (acceptance for local qualifications)	Work experience	Salary benefits
Skilled Opportunities in the construction sector: welder, bender, steel fabricator, electrician, wall painter, shuttering carpenter, gypsum worker, plumber, pipe fabricator, mason, tile mason, construction helper Hospitality sector: waiter, steward, kitchen helper, delivery (driver), cook, assistant cook	The German Tech, technical college and related vocational training qualifications (NVQ levels 4-7) are recognized. Driver applicants with experience must have a heavy-vehicle driving license. All applicants must have fluency in English.	A minimum work experience of 3-5 years is required for all skilled categories. Hotel management experience required for the hospitality sector. And low-skilled applicants are not required to have a service certificate, but they must sit for the skill assessment test.	Skilled and semi-skilled labourers earn US\$600-\$1,200 per month.
Semi-skilled Drivers: JCB operator, excavator, asphalt operator			
Low-skilled Domestic helper			

Long-term opportunities, 3-5 years
Skilled worker in construction, heavy-vehicle drivers

Recommendations for Romania

Key messages

- Most available job opportunities are in the skilled and semi-skilled sector currently

Recommendations

- Compulsory English language training should be included in the curriculum at the technical and vocational centre study programmes or initiate public-private partnerships to provide language courses for migrants before their departure.
- A formal channel should be established through the Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment for interested migrant workers to access jobs in Romania.



Canada

► Background

5. Canada

a. Migrant population in Canada

Although Canada reached the same scoring as Japan and, like Japan, was not in Sri Lanka's traditional pool of destinations, it falls into tenth place. Nonetheless, Canada has a significant population of foreign migrants and a significant volume of remittances globally.

According to Canada's Census data, migrants constituted a quarter of the population (23 per cent) in 2021, the highest among the G7 countries.²⁹ This proportion is projected to grow to around 34 per cent by 2041, at 8,049,323 persons and with more women than men among them (figures 39 and 40).

Figure 5.1. International migrants in Canada, by gender, 2020

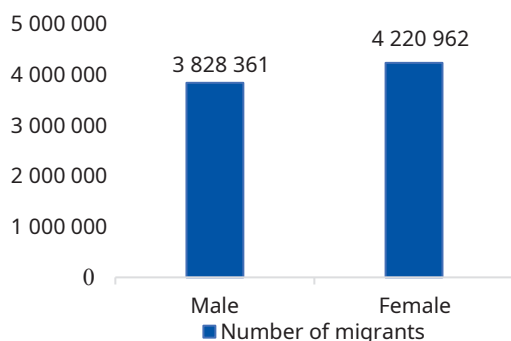
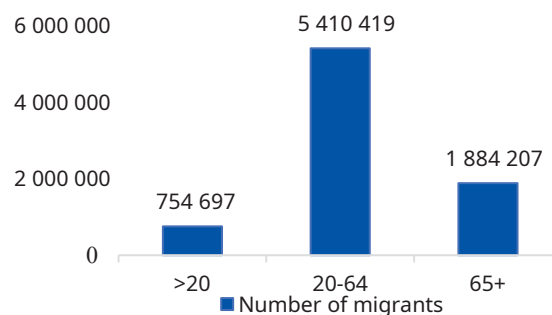


Figure 5.2. International migrants in Canada, by age category, 2020



Source: UN DESA, Population Division, "International Migration Stock 2020".

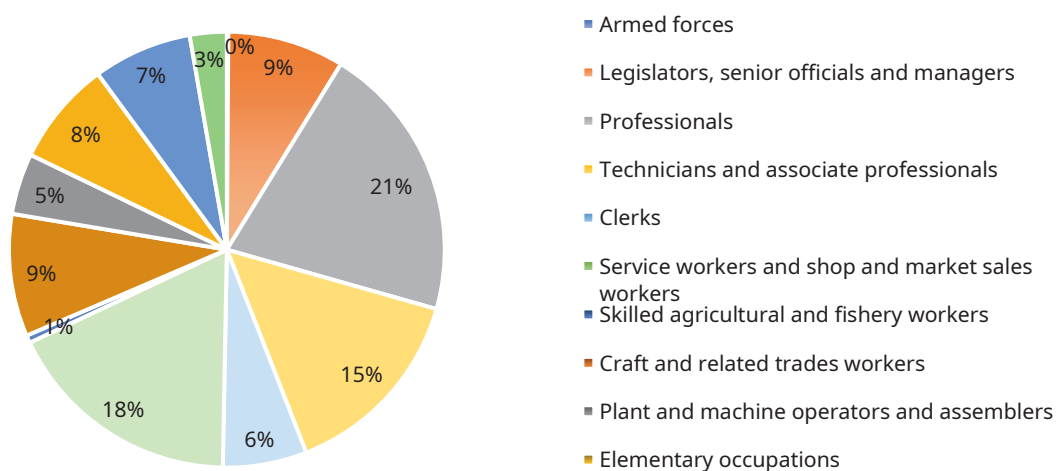
According to OECD data, the foreign-born employment rate in 2021 in Canada was 73.3 per cent, which was higher than the average for OECD countries (at 69.2 per cent). Similarly, the foreign-born labour market participation rate was higher than the OECD average, at 80.1 per cent, and 75.7 per cent, respectively, in 2021.³⁰

Canada's Census population data for 2016 (latest available data) indicate that the majority of migrants were working in professional categories (figure 41).

²⁹ Statistics Canada, "Immigrants Make Up the Largest Share of the Population in Over 150 Years and Continue to Shape Who We Are As Canadians", 26 October 2022.

³⁰ OECD, International Migration Outlook 2022, 2022.

Figure 5.3. Percentage of foreign-born population in Canada, by occupation, 2016



Source: UN DESA, “Economically Active Foreign-Born Population By Occupation, Age, Sex and Urban/Rural Residence”, 2016 (latest available data).

In 2020, the top-five migrant-sending countries to Canada were India, China, Philippines, the United Kingdom and the United States (table 26).

Table 5.1. Top-five migrant-sending countries to Canada, 2020

Country	Migrant population
India	720 083
China	699 190
Philippines	633 547
United Kingdom	537 504
United States	273 226

Source: IOM, *World Migration Report 2022*, 2022.

b. Migration policy in Canada³¹

Canada offers a world-leading migration system that has evolved through several adaptations to encourage more migrants. As cited in the OECD's International Migration Outlook 2022, the Immigration Plan 2022–24 aims to increase the number of new permanent residents to around 1 per cent of the population per year. The Atlantic Immigration Programme was launched to support the growth ambition, including:

1. Overall admissions amounting to 1.1 per cent of the Canadian population by 2024.
2. A long-term focus on economic growth, with nearly 60 per cent of admissions in the Economic Class.
3. Help for vulnerable populations, like the special measures for granting permanent residence to refugee claimants working in health care during the pandemic.
4. Support for global crises by providing a safe haven through humanitarian immigration to persons facing persecution.
5. Talent retention of persons already in Canada by granting permanent status to temporary residents accepted through the time limited

pathways for essential workers launched in spring 2021.

The Economic Mobility Pathways pilot was initiated to address the labour shortage in high-demand sectors with skilled refugees. Amendments to the Citizenship Act were made, along with a special resettlement initiative for Afghans and human rights defenders. And a Canada-Ukraine Authorization for Emergency Travel was adopted.

During the pandemic period, Canada followed a unique procedure to facilitate migrants, such as shifting language training to online delivery, and allocation of resources for protection from gender-based violence during the pandemic.

Canada is working to digitalize its migration governance over the next five years. This will require investment in an enterprise-wide digital migration management platform to improve the digital tools for application processing and other businesses.

c. Labour demand and trends in Canada³²

Analysis of government data by CBC News highlighted that many industries had increased their number of employees between 2019 and 2022, along with their growth rate, while a few industries were reducing their production (table 27).

31 Source of information for this section: Government of Canada, "New Immigration Plan to Fill Labour Market Shortages and Grow Canada's Economy", Press statement, 14 February 2022; OECD, *International Migration Outlook 2022*, 2022.

32 Source of information for this section: Benjamin Shingler and Graeme Bruce, "In a Tight Labour Market, This Is Where Canadian Workers Are Going", CBC, 23 August 2022.

Table 5.2. Growth sectors and sectors with decline in labour in Canada, 2019–22 (%)

Growth sectors		Sectors in decline	
Professional, scientific and technical services	19.5	Transportation and warehousing	-2.3
Public administration	17.1	Forestry, fishing, mining, quarrying, oil and gas	-5.1
Finance, insurance, real estate, rental and leasing	14.4	Agriculture	-10.7
Information, culture and recreation	10.3	Business, building and other support services	-11.6
Educational services	10.2	Other services (except public administration)	-12.4
Construction	6.5	Accommodation and food services	-14.2
Health care and social assistance	5		
Wholesale and retail trade	4		
Manufacturing	0.7		
Utilities	0.4		

Note: Data is for all labour, Canadian and migrant.

Source: Benjamin Shingler and Graeme Bruce, “In a Tight Labour Market, This Is Where Canadian Workers Are Going”, CBC, 23 August 2022.

According to Fabian Lange, a labour economist, many workers are climbing the job ladder towards industries with better compensation and benefits. Therefore, as the CBC report acknowledged, it may signal a trend of workers shifting from food services

and agriculture to higher-paying quality jobs in manufacturing, health care and social assistance, in line with their skills and expertise. The CBC report also cited wage increases in various industries from 2019 to 2022, such as the five highlighted in table 28.

Table 5.3. Top-five industries with increased wages in Canada, 2019 Q1–2022 Q1 (%)

Industry	Change in average offered hourly wage
Information and cultural industries	25
Agriculture, forestry, fishing and hunting	21
Arts, entertainment and recreation	18
Other services (except public administration)	17
Real estate and rental and leasing	16

Source: Benjamin Shingler, and Graeme Bruce, “In a Tight Labour Market, This Is Where Canadian Workers Are Going”, CBC, 23 August 2022.

Among the top-five industries, three of them are depicted in table 27 under the sectors that have grown in number of employees as well.

The CBC report stressed that Canada's labour force participation rate is steadily declining, and the leading factor driving down the rate is changing composition and characteristics of the population, such as ageing. Government statistics revealed that the population share of retirement-age persons is rapidly rising, and this requires more capable individuals for the work force. Additionally, the Canadian Government reported that the worker-to-retiree ratio will drop to only 3:1 in the future, and this as a sign of strong economic need for increased immigration.

According to government statistics, immigrants in 2021 accounted for 13 per cent of the workforce in the accommodation and food services sector, 11

per cent in the professional services sector, and 10 per cent in the manufacturing and transportation sectors. Between 2010 and 2018, there was a 35 per cent increase in earnings for all new economic immigrants. However, the government statistics also reveal challenges related to skill utilization of migrants, especially for high-skilled workers. Temporary foreign workers and international students have also become an important resource to fill the labour shortages.

d. Migration to Canada from Sri Lanka

According to the Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment, only 29 Sri Lankans registered as migrant workers in Canada in 2021, up from 14 migrants in 2018 and 20 in 2019. Among them, only seven were women (figures 42 and 43).

Figure 5.4. Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment-registered migrants in Canada, 2021

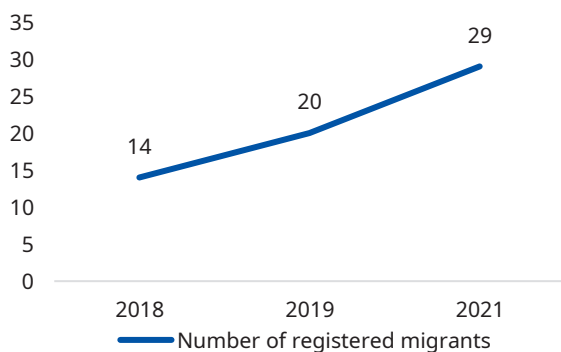
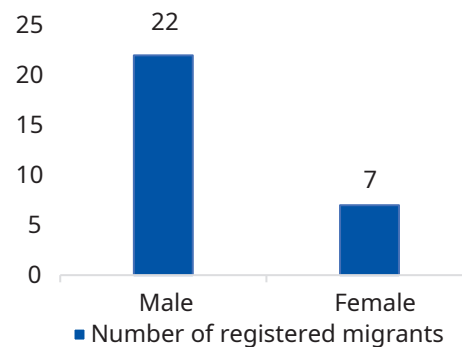


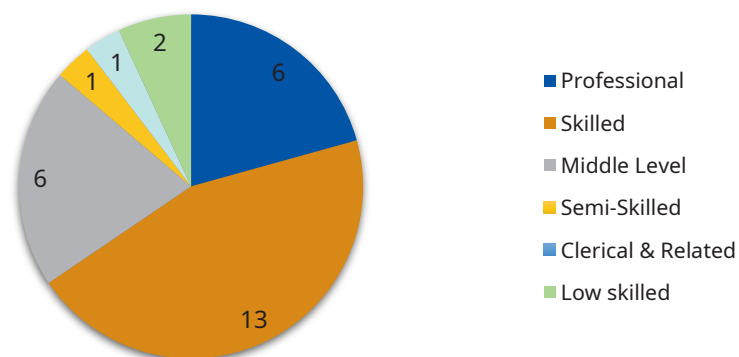
Figure 5.5. Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment-registered migrants in Canada, by gender, 2021



Source: Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment statistics, 2021.

The largest proportion of migrants in Canada who were registered with the Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment in 2021 had jobs in the skilled category (figure 44).

Figure 5.6. Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment-registered migrants to Canada, by skill category, 2021



Source: Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment statistics, 2021.

According to KNOMAD's bilateral remittance matrix, remittances from Canada to Sri Lanka placed it among the top-five destination countries, at US\$402 million in 2021.³³

The Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment's vacancies webpage lists two job categories with 32 positions available for Sri Lankan migrants.³⁴

³³ KNOMAD, "Bilateral Remittance Matrix 2021", n.d.

³⁴ SLBFE, Foreign Job Vacancies", n.d.

Canadian labour market demand

Recruitment pathways	Challenges and barriers	Skill gaps to be bridged	Visa process
Applicants find job opportunities through personal contacts, agents, migration consultants, websites and the government website – Canada connect. Canada has one of the most generous immigration policies in the world, with many pathways for skilled workers to apply for Canada permanent residency. Express Entry is Canada's fastest and most popular immigration programme. Candidates that apply through the Express Entry system can receive permanent residence status as fast as six months. The country also offers many immigration programmes specifically designed for software engineers. Skilled migrants who come with a visit visa can search for a job and convert the visitor visa into a work permit, though they need to renew their contract annually.	• Lack of English fluency to converse • Indian IT professionals find more job opportunities due to language proficiency • Government restrictions imposed time to time on migration policy • Most professionals sacrifice their current job and engage in lower-level job • Some low-level jobseekers are qualified with degree or master's degree or professional qualifications • Difficulty level of the TOFEL and IELTS exams (Many students consider IELTS easier than TOEFL, especially the reading sections. In IELTS, the reading question samples are from magazines, books, journals and newspapers. The TOEFL reading passages are from academic textbooks and academic publications.) • Lack of soft skills and skills to follow instructions • Need for structured and organized mindset and high level of integrity • Analytical ability • Good verbal and written communication skills in English • Must pass physical, drug screen and background and pre-employment screening checks • The severe cold climate may be a challenge for some to survive.	• Language proficiency in English • Soft skills and knowledge in the use of technology • Country-specific information • Use of technology and devices	Work permits are issued in two pathways: the International Mobility Program and the Temporary Foreign Worker Program. The work visa is offered through the employer only. The visit visa (tourist) is valid for 90 days. Arrival of foreigners to Canada has increased through student visa since the Government relaxed regulations on work permit for students. Student visa through the affiliated university. The Government offers unlimited number of working hours for students for part-time jobs. Permanent residency is possible and many people migrate as a family, considering the benefits for children. Family sponsorships are allowed, including for a spouse, partner, children, parents and grandparents. The Express Entry Program is the quickest way to get permanent residency in Canada. However, one must be a highly skilled individual to get into this programme. The pathway is points-based, and applicants will score on their experience, qualifications, education and skills. This is a stream within the express entry programme. Many migrants enter the country with a visit visa and then get a work permit. Within 2 years, they can apply for permanent residency.

Canadian labour market demand

Immediate and mid-term opportunities, 1–2 years		
Job category	Required qualifications (acceptance for local qualifications)	Work experience
Professional and skilled Nurse, caregiver (widely available – nursing is among the most in-demand jobs due to a labour shortage that is expected to persist) Laboratorist, lab assistant, immunologist, allergiologist Software and hardware engineer (IT sector has more hardware and software engineering, cyber security-related opportunities; Canada offers migration programme for software engineers) Mechanical engineering, electrical engineering technician, construction project manager estimator, project engineer, civil engineering, project manager and civil engineering technician (most in-demand jobs) Skilled technician: electrician, plumber, welder in construction field Hospitality: chef, restaurant staff <i>*Professionals can engage in a lower category of job and then find suitable opportunities with their qualifications and skills.</i>	Sri Lankan academic qualifications and professional qualifications are recognized. Most of the professional applicants need a degree, but that degree should be obtained in the Canadian education system. Applicants need to follow the Canadian qualifications to practise as medical practitioners and to pursue another degree in Canada to be a professional in that area. Medical practitioner applicants must have a Bachelor of Medicine or Bachelor of Surgery to practise directly because the basic level of study to practice is postgraduate medicine in the United States. International medical graduates need to complete some supervised medical training or assessment to make sure they meet licensure educational requirements. International doctors also must complete a year of supervised medical training and practice before they can be allowed to practise in Canada. Nurse applicants must have a degree in nursing and Sri Lanka nursing registration. Caregivers must have a certificate course in caregiving for the adult caregivers. * Required to follow Canadian Nursing school programme to obtain the registration to perform as a nurse. There are ample opportunities for newcomers to work in nursing in cities across the country. German Tech, technical colleges and related vocational training qualifications (NVQ levels 4–7) are recognized. TOFEL or English language proficiency is essential for professional and skilled. Civil engineer applicants must have a vocational training institution qualification.	Minimum work experience of 3–5 years is required for professional and skilled categories. Health sector employees must fulfil training hours in Canada.
Long-term opportunities, 3–5 years		

Nurse, adult caregiver (Registered nurses work in traditional and specialized health care settings or in other community settings, such as hospitals, nursing homes, extended-care facilities, community health agencies, health centres and walk-in clinics. Nurses may also be self-employed. There is a movement towards community-based health care, so in the future, there may be fewer jobs in hospitals and more in public health areas. While the pandemic created an urgent need, the demand for registered nurses stems from Canada's ageing population, which will require more health services. The increasing demand is also affected by nurses who are retiring from the workforce. For registered nurses and registered psychiatric nurses, new job openings are projected for 2019–28 (arising from expansion demand and replacement demand) to total 191,100, while 154,600 new jobseekers (arising from school leavers, immigration and mobility) are expected to be available to fill them, according to the Canadian Occupational Projections System.)

IT professional in software development, cyber security and AI (more opportunities and highly paid jobs)

Electrical engineer, civil engineer in construction field

Green energy and technology engineer and technician

Laboratory staff, including immunologist, allergiologist

Education sector: pre-grade childcare assistant

Construction sector: plumber, mason, welder

Canadian labour market demand

Sector	Skill category	Occupation category	Education and Skill requirements	Time period	Salary benefits
Professional, scientific and technical services	Skilled, professional	Business intelligence analyst Business development professional Manager Engineer (mining, geology, petroleum, civil, mechanical, electric, etc.) Graphic designer and illustrator Desktop publishing operator and related occupations Web designer and developer	Applicants must have a bachelor's degree or relevant certification, with or without experience. Time management and communication skills are expected.	2020–30	According to 2023 figures, the average (mean) salary in Canada is CA\$72,200 per year, or \$6,017 per month, for full-time employees. The average full time caregiver salary in Canada is CA\$35,588 per year or CA\$18.25 per hour. Entry-level positions start at CA\$29,250 per year, while most experienced workers make up to CA\$44,967 per year. The average nurse salary in Canada is CA\$71,894 per year or CA\$36.87 per hour. Entry-level positions start at CA\$57,383 per year. IT sector and engineering jobs are among the well-paid jobs in the labour market.
Public administration					
Finance, insurance, real estate, rental, leasing	Semi-skilled, skilled	Securities agent, investment dealers and broker Other financial officer	Applicants must have a degree or post-secondary education plus industry experience, a strong understanding of financial terminology, skills in handling MS office package and communication and presentation skills. They also must have proficiency in English and other languages (exceptional) and a driving license. Owning a vehicle is preferred for brokers.	2020–30	
Information, culture, recreation	Semi-skilled, skilled	Supervisor, library, correspondence and related information worker Supervisor, mail and message distribution occupations	Applicants must have a degree or a secondary education qualification, with excellent matching or recognition skills and the ability to pay close attention to detail. They also must have basic knowledge of relevant computer systems.	2020–30	
Educational services	Skilled, professional	Post-secondary teaching and research assistant	Applicants must have a degree or a college or non-university certificate. They must have research skills, with at least 1 year of experience.	2020–30	

Canadian labour market demand

Sector	Skill category	Occupation category	Education and Skill requirements	Time period	Salary benefits
Construction	Semi-skilled	Construction millwright and industrial mechanic	Applicants must have the relevant professional qualification, a millwright certificate or equivalent, industry experience (3–5 years), skills in interpersonal relationships, leadership, handling MS office package, good communication and a team spirit.	2020–30	
Health care, social assistance	Skilled, professional	Specialist physician Registered nurses and registered psychiatric nurse Dentist Pharmacist Dietitians and nutritionist Health policy researcher, consultant and programme officer	Applicants must have a degree in medicine, health sciences, public health or a relevant professional qualification (licensing by the College of Pharmacists of British Columbia, for example), experience in a relevant field, relevant licensure by provincial or territorial authorities, ability to maintain effective relationships and time management skills.	2020–30	
Wholesale and retail trade	Semi-skilled, skilled	Technical sales specialist for wholesale trade	Applicants must have a school graduate degree in a business-related field, the ability to work with MS office package and have good interpersonal and communication skills.	2020–30	
Manufacturing					
Utilities	Skilled, professional	Utilities manager	Applicants must be a school graduate or have professional qualification in a relevant field, with experience in a similar sector (3–5 years), along with skills for working in a challenging environment, driving changes and strong communication.	2020–30	

Canadian labour market demand

Recommendations for Canada

- The Canadian Government's website for migrant workers is Canada Connect, and there is need to create awareness of it among potential migrants in Sri Lanka.
- There is also need to establish a formal pathway through the Ministry of Foreign Employment and the Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment for aspiring migrant workers to discover Canadian job opportunities.
- An MOU with the relevant authorities and the Ministry of Foreign Employment in Sri Lanka, through the Canadian Embassy, would help to identify the job categories that are in demand that Sri Lankans could fill.
- Public-private partnerships should be initiated to enhance the language skills of aspiring migrants to prepare them for work in Canada as well as impart other country specifics, like information on the climate, job ethics, values and the culture to prepare them for life in Canada.
- There should be a government-to-government MOU to obtain job quotas from Canada because there is much potential.
- The most available and easily accessed job opportunities are in the blue-collar and skilled categories , which should thus be targeted.

Specific requirements for medical practitioners in Canada

To become a medical doctor in Canada, an individual needs to earn a bachelor's degree, which takes four years. After completing, enter medical school, followed by a residency programme, which typically takes three to five years. Admission to medical school is very competitive and requires having a high grade point average. An individual must pass the Medical College Admission Test with a high score. Medical school should be registered in the world directory of medical schools. The Medical Council of Canada should verify that immigrants' medical credentials are equivalent to the Canadian credential. The Medical Council of Canada Qualifying Examination Part 1 should be passed before arriving in Canada. An applicant should have 12 months of training in their home country. Licentiate of the Medical Council of Canada fees must be paid. An applicant must have a work permit, be proficient in English, pass the local licensee and the Medical Study-abroad Aptitude Test and pass the Medical Council of Canada Evaluating Examination. It is taken at the end of medical studies and before residency.

Specific requirements for nurses in Canada

An applicant must first apply to the National Nursing Assessment Service and submit documents that will allow them to register as a nurse in Canada. It is a national online application service developed by nursing regulatory bodies in Canada. Applying to the National Nursing Assessment Service is an essential first step to work in Canada and an applicant must have an account with the Service. Once this is set up, the applicant can submit all relevant documents and complete the file. The National Nursing Assessment Service will evaluate the applicant's file and provide an Advisory Report. There is a demand for registered nurses with skills and experience in specialty areas, such as emergency, critical care and operating room, and for nurses willing to work in smaller or isolated communities. Applicants must have completed a nursing programme that is equivalent to a four-year bachelor's degree in nursing or a practical nursing diploma, and they must have evidence of their nursing practice. This is in the category for which the nurse applicant is applying within the three years prior to issuance of a Certificate of Registration. Applicants applying for registered nurse must have completed the Canadian Practical Nurse Registration Exam for those applying for a registered practical nurse. Also, completion of the Registered Nurse and Registered Practical Nurse Jurisprudence Examination. Evidence of language proficiency in either English or French is required.



United States of America

► Background

6. United States of America

a. Migrant population in the United States

The United States ranked fifth in the study's scoring system, with the largest migrant population globally and as a top remittance contributor to Sri Lanka. Regarding the migrant flow to the United States, there is no reliable picture; more data are needed, as are new approaches to this potential destination country for Sri Lankan workers.

As depicted in the Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development's (OECD) country profile for the United States in 2019, 14 per cent of the population was foreign born. The estimated total migrant population (all persons) in 2020 was 50,632,836, with more women than men among them (figures 22 and 23).

Figure 6.1. International migrants in the United States, by gender, 2020

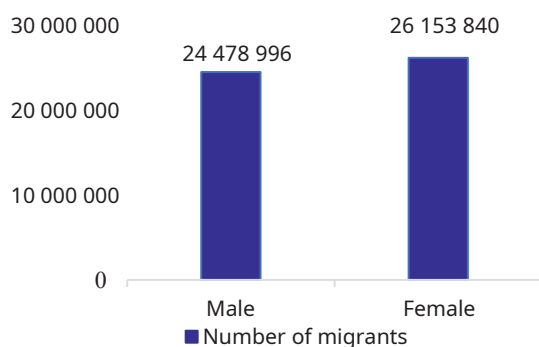
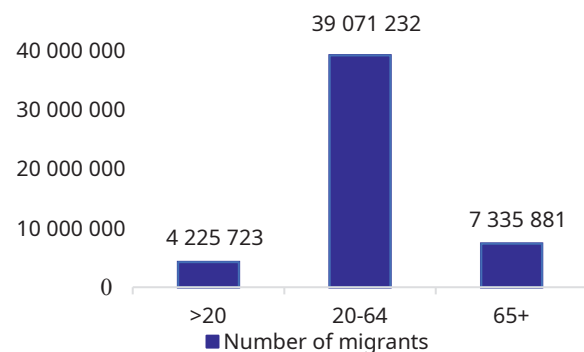


Figure 6.2. International migrants in the United States, by age category, 2020



Source: UN DESA, Population Division, "International Migration Stock 2020".

The OECD's labour market outlook for the United States shows that foreign-born labour force participation in 2021 was 74.2 per cent and the foreign-born employment rate was 70 per cent. According to 2020 OECD statistics, the long-term migrant (all persons) flow into the United States consisted of family migrants (61 per cent). Migrant workers accounted for 11 per cent), as did

accompanying family members of workers and migrants for humanitarian purposes.³⁶

According to International Organization for Migration data, the top-five migrant-sending countries to the United States in 2020 were Mexico (by far), India, China, Philippines and El Salvador.

36 OECD, *International Migration Outlook 2022*, 2022.

Table 6.1. Top-five migrant-sending countries to the United States, 2020

Country	Migrant population
Mexico	10 853 105
India	2 723 764
China	2 184 110
Philippines	2 061 178
El Salvador	1 410 659

Source: IOM, *World Migration Report 2022*, 2022

b. Migration policy in the United States³⁷

As per the OECD's International Migration Outlook 2021, the Government reviewed the country's migration policies to ensure a safe and humane immigration system. The initiative led to the welcoming of refugees and greater promotion of legal immigration, as well as citizenship. But then the country reverted to WHAT I DON'T KNOW... turned to their previous public charge rules which was a court order given in 2019. The Government is collaborating with other stakeholders mainly focused on wide spreading the awareness on public charge rules among the community with respect to public health and ongoing vaccination programmes during the pandemic period.

However, President Biden's immigration policy proposal includes reforms to undo restrictions made during the Trump administration, including the lifting of restrictions established during the pandemic period. The reforms seek to provide unauthorized immigrants a pathway to legal status and an eight-year pathway to citizenship; promote family-based immigration; revise employment-based visa rules; and increase the number of diversity visas. Revising the employment-based visa rules includes increasing the number of employment-based Permanent Resident Cards (Green Cards) issued to foreign workers and their families and increasing the number of diversity visas to 80,000 for persons from underrepresented nations. Also, President Biden's proposal is seeking a review of the contractionary policies that the previous administration had adopted for H1-B visas, which are given to highly skilled foreign workers.

Aligning with strategies adopted for COVID-19 pandemic, the Department of Homeland Security offered certification to employ temporary workers, pending their final approval. The Department also introduced measures to accelerate the processing of employment authorization applications as well as for student applicants who complete the Optional Practical Training within the 14-month period after approval of work authorization.

c. Labour demand and trends in the United States

The US Bureau of Labor Statistics reported that the American Government expects to add 8.3 million jobs between 2021 and 2031 to the country's labour market. The leisure and hospitality sector was the most expected sector for the fastest employment growth in 2021, after the pandemic period. During this period of 2021–31, the health care and social assistance sectors are predicted to be the largest job creation sector in the United States. This is due to the growth of the population older than 65. This trend is expected to lead to more demand for elderly care occupations and other health care opportunities. In addition, the Bureau has projected a change in wages and salaries for the same time period, with the leisure and hospitality, health care and social assistance, mining and education services having high rates of wage increases while manufacturing, retail trade, federal government and utilities may have decreases. Table 16 reflects the ten fastest-growing occupations expected in 2021–31.

37 Information sources for this section: see Pew Research Center, "Key Facts About U.S. Immigration Policies and Biden's Proposed Changes", 11 January 2022; OECD, *International Migration Outlook 2021*, 2021.

Table 6.2. Ten-fastest growing occupations and median annual wages in the United States, 2021–31 (US\$)

Occupation	Median annual wage, May 2021
Nurse practitioners	\$120 680
Umpires, referees and other sports officials	\$56 260
Statisticians	\$24 440
Information security analysts	\$29 350
Athletes and sports competitors	\$30 010
Data scientists	\$100 910
Cooks, restaurant staff	\$77 300
Motion picture projectionists	\$102 600
Ushers, lobby attendants and ticket takers	\$95 570
Wind turbine service technicians	\$35 860

Source: Bureau of Labor Statistics, “Employment Projections, 2021–2031”.

d. Migration to the United States from Sri Lanka

The Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment has no data on Sri Lankans migrating to the United States for work. According to KNOMAD’s bilateral remittance matrix, the United States was among the top-ten remittance contributors to Sri Lanka in 2021, at US\$158 million).³⁸

On the Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment’s vacancies page, there are three types of job categories for the United States, and most of them are in the health sector. Altogether, there are 138 approved vacancies, and all of them are still available for Sri Lankans.³⁹

³⁸ KNOMAD, “Bilateral Remittance Matrix 2021”, n.d.

³⁹ Bureau of Foreign Employment, “Foreign Job Vacancies”, n.d.

United States of America labour market demand

Recruitment pathways	Challenges and barriers	Skill gaps to be bridged	Visa process
Job opportunities found through personal contacts, LinkedIn and websites.	- Lack of English fluency to converse - Compared to Indians, Sri Lankans lack soft skills - Requirements to obtain approved qualifications, license to perform the professional job categories for medical practitioners - Climatic changes and adaptation - High cost of living and taxation - Must pass physical, drug screen and background or pre-employment screening checks	- Language proficiency in English (required for all jobs) - Soft skills, such as analytical ability - Good verbal and written communication skills in English - Right combination of skills, education and/or work experience	Work visa through the employer has to be applied from the Department of State. The H-1B visa is the most popular visa for professionals in specialty occupations, such as doctor or engineer. An Employment Authorization (EAD) card allows applicants to seek jobs if they have a dependant and their spouse has a job. O-1 visa is granted to applicants with remarkable talent or accomplishments in their field. EB-3 refers to the low-skilled labour visa category and is the “3rd preference” of employment-based visas. A foreign national can obtain the EB-3 low-skilled visa by either (a) adjusting their status in the United States from a student visa or other type of visa to the EB-3 visa or (b) applying overseas to be interviewed at the local American Embassy or Consulate. A permanent labour certification issued by the Department of Labor allows an employer to hire a foreign worker to work permanently in the country. The employer offers the position to the foreign national, contingent on there being no qualified American worker who will apply for the position in the subsequent recruitment. A Permanent Resident Card (Green Card) is available based on eligibility criteria. Student visa is available for postgraduate or master’s programmes at universities.

Immediate and mid-term opportunities, 1-2 years		
Job category	Required qualifications (acceptance for local qualifications)	Work experience
Professional and skilled Nurse, caregiver, medical doctor Software and hardware engineers (IT sector has more hardware and software engineering, cyber security-related opportunities) Electrical engineer (in construction, power plants), biomedical and chemical engineer Business process outsourcing that follows a hybrid working process Low-skilled persons must pursue sponsorships and be willing to fill openings with the help of an EB-3 low-skilled visa for industries like janitorial, restaurants, packing, warehousing, food prep and fast food	Sri Lankan academic qualifications and professional qualifications are recognized. It is mandatory to adhere to the qualifying exams to practise as medical and health professionals. Medical professionals (doctors and nurses) must follow the qualifications. Medical practitioners are required to pass the required medical licensing exam. Most migrants, even with experience in practising with foreign qualifications, are required to re-enrol academically, especially when curriculum differs overseas. They are called International Medical Graduates (31.8 per cent of physicians in the country are foreign trained).	Minimum work experience of 3-5 years for all professional and skilled categories. Any foreign doctor who wants to practise medicine in the United States must pass the medical licensing exam to obtain certification. Nurses are required to pass the National Council Licensing Examination-Registered Nurse.

United States of America labour market demand

Immediate and mid-term opportunities, 1-2 years		
Job category	Required qualifications (acceptance for local qualifications)	Work experience
	To enter a fellowship or residency programme approved by the Accreditation Council for Graduate Medical Education, the Bachelor of Medicine, Bachelor of Surgery students, Indian medical graduates, foreign medical graduates or completed Medical Doctor who want to settle in the United States in the future, the medical licensing exam is the only option to get certified and start a medical practice in the country. Nurse applicants must have a degree in nursing and the Sri Lanka nursing registration. They are required to pass the National Council Licensing Examination-Registered Nurse. Caregivers need a certificate course in caregiving for adults. Language proficiency in English with a test score at a high band is essential. Skill assessment test results during the selection process for migration visa.	

Long-term opportunities, 3-5 years

IT sector: software engineer, AI specialist, cyber security expert
 Engineer in green energy, from technology engineer to power plant-based energy engineer
 Hospitality sector: chef

Hiring international nurses and doctors is becoming increasingly common in the hospitals of Pennsylvania. For example, Highmark Health, Geisinger Health System, Trinity Health, and Kindred Hospital have all prioritized a programme for hiring foreign medical professionals to provide excellent patient care.

The federal Government had projected that more than 200,000 new registered nurse positions will be created each year from 2016 to 2026. The United States is always looking for experienced health care workers, especially nurses, because they are in high demand. For years, experts in the health care field have sounded the alarm on the high demand for nurses nationwide. Based on projections by the US Bureau of Labor Statistics, the country will need an additional 203,200 registered nurses each year, from now through 2031.

Because the ageing population is high in the United States, there will be more demand for adult caregiver jobs in the long term as well.

**Demand for related jobs that provide support to physicians and other health care providers are likely to be the most in demand. There's a high demand need for physical therapy aides, home health aides and medical assistants.*

United States of America labour market demand

Sector	Skill category	Occupation category	Education and Skill requirements	Time period	Comments	Salary benefits
Leisure and hospitality	Skilled, semi-skilled	Cook Restaurant Usher Lobby attendant Ticket taker	Applicants must have a high school diploma or equivalent, with proven industry experience, relevant certification for the occupation. Strong interpersonal and communication skills, high organization skills, knowledge of MS office package and proficiency in language (English) are essential.	2021-31	Potential market but requires proficiency in English	The average annual wage is US\$74,738. Highest paid professional categories average US\$117,360 per annum. Semi-skilled and low-skilled are paid US\$45,450 per annum. Median wage for employees in health care support occupations is about US\$33,600.
Health care and social assistance	Low-skilled	Elderly care	Experience in similar role, compassion, relevant certification and training is preferred.	2021-31	Market potential very high but requires proficiency in English	
	Skilled, professional	Nurse practitioner	Applicants must have a valid license as defined by the Nurse Licensure Compact, degree or equivalent qualification, nearly 5 years of experience and strong oral and written communication skills.		Market potential very high but requires proficiency in English	
Sports	Skilled, semi-skilled	Umpire, referee, other sports official, athlete, sports competitor	Applicants must be older than 18 years, have sport-specific coaching experience and knowledge, excellent communication skills, pass a criminal background check, skills in leadership, time management and meeting deadlines.	2021-31		
Mining						
Educational services	University lecturers	Academic position	Applicants must have a PhD from an American university plus teaching experience. Research publications are required.	2021-25		
Data and information technology	Skilled, professional	Statistician Information security analyst Data scientist	Applicants must have a bachelor's or advanced degree, preferably in a technology-related field or equivalent, experience in relevant field, such as machine learning, analysing structured and unstructured datasets, using data mining process models. Skills in MS office package, ability to apply new technologies with little instruction and proficiency in statistical computer languages (Python, R, SQL, etc.) and machine learning methods are expected. Good communication skills is preferred.	2021-31	Market potential very high	
Services	Semi-skilled	Wind turbine service technician	Applicants must have a postsecondary or non-degree qualification.			

United States of America labour market demand

Recommendations for United Arab Emirates

Key messages

- There is high demand mainly in health, ICT, green energy and hospitality sector occupations.
- There is a high level of unfilled vacancies in the health sector, particularly for doctors, nurses, and caregivers. Projected demand for newly registered nurse positions will be 200,000 per annum from 2016 to 2026.
- Wages and benefits are highly attractive, with average annual wages at US\$74,738 per annum.
- In the medium and long term, health sector workers have the highest potential in the United States.
- English language proficiency is a mandatory requirement for all categories of employees.
- There is a strict procedure for recognition of foreign qualifications.

Recommendations

- The US Citizenship and Immigration Services should be used as a government source to create awareness of the opportunities in the country. The Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment can have a link to this site.
- Professional and semi-skilled migration should get greater concentration.
- The Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment should maintain a separate job portal for the United States.
- Education and training should be expanded into high-demand sectors, such as medical doctors, nurses and adult caregivers.
- Evidence-based migration should be promoted; for example, encourage interested migrant workers to use LinkedIn and other personal pathways.
- Mutually beneficial migration should continue through bilateral labour agreements.

Specific requirements for medical practitioners – Doctors

- Most migrants with experience in practising with foreign qualifications require re-enrolling academically, especially when the curriculum differs from overseas training.
- They are called international medical graduates; 31.8 per cent of physicians are foreign trained in the United States.
- It is longer for an international medical graduate to become a doctor than a medical school graduate of an American school.
- Visas are possible to work as a doctor in the United States:
 - H1B VIA – international medical graduate physicians are restricted to work in the location mentioned in their non-immigrant petition and labour condition application.
 - J1 Visa
 - O-1 Visa
 - TN Visa (only for Canadian and Mexican citizens).
 - Immigrant visa (permanent residency, Green Card)
- Applicants must receive Educational Commission for Foreign Medical Graduates verification that the degree obtained by foreign medical graduates is listed on the World Directory of Medical Schools.
- Applicants must complete all missing medical education requirements.
- Applicants must pass the required United States' medical licensing exams.
- Applicants must go through residency programmes for foreign medical graduates.
- Applicants must obtain final certification from the Educational Commission for Foreign Medical Graduates.

Specific requirements for nurses

- Applicants can transform any bachelor's degree into a nursing degree. Migrants can become a registered nurse in two years with the Accelerated Nursing Master Entry Professional Nursing programme, which is designed for highly motivated individuals who have a prior bachelor's degree in a non-nursing field. Once admitted, students must maintain a 3.0 or greater cumulative grade point average throughout the programme. This accelerated, year-round programme allows qualified individuals to graduate with a Master of Science in Nursing following completion of two years of full-time study.
- Participation in this combined undergraduate and master's degree programme at Western Kentucky University will allow individuals to concurrently complete a Bachelor of Science in Nursing and a Master of Science in Nursing. Following completion of the Master Entry Professional Nursing programme, individuals are eligible to sit for the licensing exam.

ILO Country Office for Sri Lanka and the Maldives

202-204, Bauddhaloka Mawatha, Colombo 07, Sri Lanka

Tel: +94 11 2500539 Fax: +94 11 2500865

Email: colombo@ilo.org

www.ilo.org/colombo

ISBN: 978-922-0403-49-5

